

# The Observer

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## COVER STORY

# Hey, Game Devs: The ‘Placeholder Assets’ Excuse For Using AI Is Running Really Thin

*We’ve been talking a lot of about the use of artificial intelligence lately, for obvious reasons.*

Timothy Geigner · Techdirt

**M**any of those conversations have revolved around the video game industry and I’ve been fairly vocal about pushing back against the “all AI is bad everywhere forever” dogma that I see far too often. There are plenty of folks in our community that don’t agree with me on that, and that’s fine. But if the picture you’re getting is that I’m an AI evangelist, that’s simply not true. There are potentially good uses of AI in my view, as well as a whole lot of potential negative outcomes of its use.

I’m not blind to that.

And, in the video game industry specifically, one bit of pushback that seems to be sorely needed is on game developers that use generative AI in their games, fail to say so, and then excuse its use as accidental after the fact. That is becoming as common a refrain from game developers as the laughable excuse in trademark instances that is, “Well, I have to be an aggressive jerk about my trademarks or else I lose them.” Neither is true.

The most recent version of this concerns the recent hit launch of *Crimson Desert*. In what is becoming something analogous to the antiquated process by which people who watch golf tournaments on TV looking for missed rules violations could then send into the PGA, which I’ve coined as *McPromptism*, new game releases get put under a microscope by people looking to find AI uses within them. *Crimson Desert* went through this process and, wouldn’t you know it, people found clear uses of AI-generated assets in the game.

The game’s extremely high fidelity and impressive graphics are a big part of the sales pitch, which made it all the more disappointing when players began to come across what appeared to be AI-generated artwork littered throughout the game. In light of the disappointment, developer Pearl Abyss has apologized for including the slop in their game, promising to remove and replace all of it.

“We also acknowledge that we should have clearly disclosed our use of AI,” the *Crimson Desert* account posted on X. “We are currently conducting a comprehensive audit of all in-game assets and are taking steps to replace any affected content. Updated assets will be rolled out in upcoming patches. In parallel, we are reviewing and strengthening our internal processes to ensure greater transparency and consistency in how we communicate with players moving forward.”

Like I said above, this excuse is getting old. Very old. Game developers and publishers will be more than aware at this point that a sizable percentage of the gaming public is very allergic to the use of AI in games, particularly when that use is not acknowledged at the forefront. If placeholder assets generated by AI are to be used at all in the development of a game, it is inexcusable for a developer to not have a process to remove them in place of human-created art before the game is published. That’s sloppy at best, and a lie of an excuse at worst.

Especially because it’s not like there aren’t other options that have nothing to do with AI.

The practice is becoming more common in AAA developer spaces, but critics argue that setting aside the use of AI in your game, it’s pretty foolish to use temporary assets that don’t call obvious attention to themselves. In games of such massive scale, BRAT-green blocks that scream “DO NOT

USE” are much easier to flag than something approximating the final product.

I’m struggling to come up with a counter-argument to that.

I’m still in a place where I think there are valid uses of AI in gaming development. If a dev or publisher wants to explore those uses and, importantly, is upfront about it, there may be a place for that.

But the excuse of laziness when it comes to stripping AI assets out when their use was not intended is lame and needs to go away.

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*In light of the disappointment, developer Pearl Abyss has apologized for including the slop in their game, promising to remove and replace all of it.*

Timothy Geigner

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## FEATURES

# Building Slack's Anomaly Event Response

Nathan Lehotsky · Slack Engineering

As cyberattacks evolve to unprecedented levels of sophistication and speed, the time gap between breach detection and response has never been more critical. Traditional security approaches often operate reactively, identifying compromises only after damage has occurred. This delay grants attackers a tactical advantage, forcing security teams to focus on damage assessment and remediation rather than proactive threat detection and prevention. Organizations urgently need solutions that dramatically compress the detection-to-response window to regain a defensive advantage.

To tackle this challenge, we've developed Anomaly Event Response (AER) – a new proactive defence mechanism inside Slack. By combining real-time monitoring with advanced analytics, AER autonomously identifies high-confidence threat actor behaviours as they emerge on our platform. When suspicious activity is detected, the system automatically terminates the associated user sessions, reducing the security detection and response gap from potential days/hours to mere minutes.

The result? A powerful native security capability that disrupts attack chains before they can be fully executed, preventing data exfiltration and system compromise without requiring additional security tools, integration, or human capital.

In this post, we'll explore the technical architecture behind Anomaly Event Response, examining our motivation, detection mechanisms, response capabilities, and the insights we gained along the way.

## The Shared Responsibility of Securing Slack

Slack is where work happens. We're a central hub for workplace communication and collaboration for tens of millions of users on a weekly basis, generating billions of interactions daily. To ensure our customers' security, we provide comprehensive audit logs to Enterprise customers that record when entities take an action on the platform. Within the full list includes hundreds of actions that we support, we also provide customers with anomaly audit logs which take a step further by leveraging advanced analytics to flag unusual activities across a workspace including irregular logins, uploading malware, unexpected data transfers, and more . Those interested in learning more about these special audit logs and how they can use them in security investigations will be interested in reading our Slack Audit Logs and Anomalies post.

These specialized audit logs serve as an early warning system, highlighting suspicious activity and providing invaluable insight into potential threats that might otherwise remain undetected. That said, they aren't a solution in and of themselves; they still require review by security person-

nel or integration with third-party solutions to translate detected behaviour into actionable insights.

Integrating your Slack audit logs into a larger security solution offers unparalleled flexibility and customizability, but we also know this isn't feasible for all customers based on their size, security capabilities, or resources. We created AER to bridge this gap between detection and response with an automated solution that any Enterprise Grid customer can use out-of-the-box, either by itself or as part of their broader security approach.

Trust is our number one core value. We believe security is a shared responsibility between us and our customers by empowering them with data and tools to build security solutions while also fostering a secure platform and neutralizing threats. Our Anomaly Event Response solution bridges threat detection and automated response for everyone while still allowing advanced customers to add tailored security measures on top of this tool to address their unique needs.

It also continues our ongoing commitment to enhancing user security with innovative automations like our measures against password breaches and cookie hijacking .

When designing this feature, we focused on supporting the most common types of threats that platforms face. Our goal was to prioritize detections that would have the broadest appeal across the platform. We landed on:

style="font-weight: 400;">Accessing Slack from a Tor exit node

style="font-weight: 400;">Excessive downloading as a potential indicator of data exfiltration

style="font-weight: 400;">Data scraping via non-Slack-native automation tools

style="font-weight: 400;">Session fingerprint mismatches

style="font-weight: 400;"> Unexpected API call volumes and patterns

style="font-weight: 400;">Unexpected user agents indicating access from non-standard or virtual clients

We know every customer uses Slack differently, and every organization is going to have a different risk profile, so we designed AER to let organizations select which detections are important to them and which should simply be logged without any responding action. This same configurability extends to notification preferences.

To make changes to your configuration, navigate via Tools and Settings → Organization settings → Security (left-hand sidebar) → Security Settings . From here, there will be an Anomaly Event Response Settings section where you can choose which anomaly events should trigger user session termination and how you would like to be notified, if at all.

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# Is Banyan Tree Mayakoba Worth It? Our Full Review

Kristin Addis · Be My Travel Muse

Banyan Tree Mayakoba is one of those resorts where you feel immersed in nature, far away from any parties or crowds, and that's exactly the point. It hits you with a big arrival moment at a dramatic lobby, then quietly pulls you into a slower rhythm almost immediately.

If you're looking for a place that feels private, green, and genuinely restful, especially when traveling with kids, this one stands out in a way that's hard to replicate elsewhere in the Riviera Maya.

When you book Banyan Tree Mayakoba through Muse Bespoke Escapes, you receive preferred partner benefits that are simple but meaningful and tend to make the stay feel easier rather than more complicated.

- ☑ Daily breakfast for two
- ☑ Resort credit to use on dining or spa treatments
- ↑ Room upgrade on arrival when available
- 🕒 Early check-in and late checkout when possible
- ☑ Priority VIP treatment at the resort

There's no script or upsell attached to this. Things just tend to flow better, and staff are aware you're arriving through a preferred channel.

You don't walk into Banyan Tree so much as you're eased into it. Located around 45 minutes from Cancun airport, just past the Ruta de Cenotes towards Playa del Carmen, Mayakoba is a serene getaway tucked behind several miles of mangrove. Check-in happens calmly, seated, and without a lot of back and forth. From there, everything is water, greenery, and quiet pathways.

The resort is built around lagoons and mangroves, so even moving from place to place feels peaceful. You hear birds constantly. Mornings are especially calm, and evenings feel unhurried.

Despite being part of the larger Mayakoba complex, Banyan Tree feels entirely separate once you're inside, yet you can easily take a duffy boat or golf cart to any of the other resorts and their restaurants as well – Rosewood Mayakoba, Fairmont Mayakoba, and soon to be the Alila Mayakoba.

Every guest stays in a private villa with its own pool, and that single detail shapes the entire experience.

Our villa — one of the newly renovated 3 bedroom villas — felt more like a small residence than a hotel room. High ceilings, lots of space, and a layout that made sense for spending real time there. There was an indoor living area, outdoor space, and a pool that felt secluded rather than on display.

There were 4 bathrooms, the main with a deep soaking tub and plenty of room to spread out. It was the kind of space you actually want to use, not just pass through.

Traveling with a child, this setup made everything easier. Naps didn't require tiptoeing around. Early bedtimes didn't mean the night was over for us. We could order room service, swim outside, and still feel relaxed.

The resort is spread out, but moving around never felt inconvenient. You get around by bike or boat, and both quickly become part of the rhythm of the stay rather than something to manage. Our toddler loved both the golf carts and the boat, so it was all part of the experience for him.

Boat rides are slow and quiet. Bikes are easy and flat, and kids tend to love them. If you don't feel like moving at all, staff are quick to come get you. Everyone and everything you need is just a call or Whatsapp message away.

Nothing about the layout feels rushed or chaotic.

The beach area is calm and understated, on a white sand beach with perfectly calm waters that are baby blue hued. No loud music, no packed loungers, and no pressure to claim a spot early. It's a place where people actually read books and stay a while. It was our favorite spot at the whole resort.

The shared pool areas are lovely, but having a private pool often meant we didn't feel the need to leave our villa unless we wanted to.

This setup works especially well for families with younger kids. There's room to splash, play, and relax without constantly packing up and moving locations.

Food at Banyan Tree Mayakoba is consistently good, but what stood out more than anything was how unique it felt.

Our favorite experience was dining at Saffron, the Thai restaurant with decks right on the water (both with and without rails depending on what makes you most comfortable with little kids). It was delicious and such a fun experience dining right on the water while looking at sea turtles and fish.

The breakfast (we especially loved the beach club!), Italian restaurant, cello, and room service were great, too.

Banyan Tree Mayakoba works well for families who want calm rather than stimulation.

There's space to roam, privacy to retreat to, and an overall environment where kids are welcome without the resort being overtly kid focused. That said, there's a kids club with a little pool, climbing area, daily activities, and in the evenings, the private villa setup does most of the heavy lifting with plenty of room for everyone and the rooftop pool.

Banyan Tree Mayakoba is a large resort that's part of a larger complex that still somehow feels quiet, spacious, and

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# It's time for Democrats to face political reality on Israel

Norman Solomon · Salon

When the governing body of the Democratic Party convenes April 9-11, it will face a challenge to its support for Israel. The Democratic National Committee has evaded the fact that large majorities of Democrats oppose continuing military aid to Israel. According to an August 2025 Quinnipiac poll, 77% of Democrats, as well as half of registered U.S. voters overall, believe the country has committed genocide — a term that remains in dispute — in Gaza under the leadership of Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu. The stage is set for jarring discord when the DNC's 450 members gather in New Orleans.

An NBC poll released March 16 underscores the depth of the DNC's political folly. Registered Democrats were asked, "Are your sympathies more with the Israelis or more with the Palestinians?" The results were lopsided: 67% to 17% in favor of Palestinians.

The DNC leadership has stayed on a collision course with political realities about Israel. Last August, while a Gallup poll was showing that just 8% of Democrats approved of Israel's military actions in Gaza, DNC chair Ken Martin said at a meeting of delegates from across the country that "there's a divide in our party on this issue." He was correct. But Martin didn't acknowledge that the crucial divide is actually between the party's leadership and its base.

Amid contention over U.S. policies toward Israel at that meeting, Martin withdrew his party-line resolution urging a "negotiated pathway toward a two-state solution" after it won — and after a pro-Palestinian rights measure advocating the "suspension of military aid to Israel" lost. He called for "shared dialogue" and "shared advocacy," announcing that he would appoint a task force "comprised of stakeholders on all sides of this to continue to have the conversation." Martin declared that "this crisis in Gaza is urgent" and an "emergency."

But the "emergency" lost its urgency as soon as the DNC adjourned and the media spotlight disappeared. Six months passed before the first meeting of the task force, which by then had been downgraded to a "working group."

The working group's convener, selected by Martin, is James Zogby, a longtime advocate for Palestinian rights who had greeted Martin's task-force announcement with praise, calling it "politically thoughtful" and a recognition of "the reality that the status quo has become unacceptable and untenable."

But more than six months after the announcement, the status quo remains undisturbed as the DNC's Middle East Working Group proceeds at a snail's pace. The composition of the eight-member panel makes it foreseeably incapable of reaching its purported goal to "help us sort out how our party deals with America's policies in the Middle East."

The working group is an oil-and-water mix of fully incompatible views on Palestinian rights and Israeli power. Some on the DNC panel want an embargo on U.S. arms to Israel, while others firmly oppose any such step. One member of the working group, Andrew Lachman, has led fights inside the California Democratic Party to thwart actions or statements critical of Israel. He is currently the president of Democrats for Israel-California.

How the DNC's appointed group is supposed to "sort out" the party's position on U.S. policy in the Middle East is inexplicable. But the project does have an evident function: The Middle East Working Group has proven itself to be a stalling mechanism. And the pretenses behind it have become even more fanciful as the U.S.-Israel military alliance persists with a war of aggression on Iran that has been setting the region on fire.

No matter how much the DNC leadership tries to shunt it aside, the burning issue of U.S. policy toward Israel will not go away. This year, it has become a key issue in one Democratic primary race after another, putting incumbent members of Congress on the defensive for their attempts to justify support for the nation or acceptance of funding from the AIPAC lobby. Yet the DNC's stance is that the party establishment is wise to seal itself off from such unpleasantness.

The committee's refusal to make public its autopsy of the 2024 election is tangled up in dodging the document's reported conclusion that Kamala Harris's rigid support for arming Israel was a significant factor in her defeat. Keeping the official autopsy under wraps, supposedly to improve the prospects of future election victories, actually makes those wins less likely by mystifying instead of clarifying electoral history.

Martin told Fox News in late February that concentrating on the future would be better than trying to "relitigate" the 2024 election. But hiding the autopsy amounts to condescension, assuming that only a small elite party circle should be privy to the results of the party's extensive (and expensive) research. Many Democratic activists and candidates would benefit from candor instead of stonewalling.

Weeks ago, the California Democratic Party responded to growing pressure from grassroots activists at its annual convention by adopting a platform that advocates "an immediate end to the mass civilian casualties, destruction, displacement and starvation of Palestinians in Gaza." The document says that "Palestinians in Gaza should be able to rebuild without displacement, with international humanitarian, economic and security assistance," and it calls for "the immediate rebuilding of Gaza with the provision of humanitarian aid, restoration of funding for [the United Nations Relief and Works Agency for Palestine Refugees] that serves the Palestinian people."

But the DNC, like the bulk of Democrats in Congress, lags far behind such grassroots outlooks. The top-down culture that prevails in the national party has stultified internal debate, rendering it scarce and pro forma. Despite Martin's

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# The Perfect Ha Long (Bai Tu Long) Cruise with Indochina Junk

Kristin Addis · Be My Travel Muse

When people picture Vietnam, they often imagine the soaring limestone karsts of Ha Long Bay, but few realize there's a quieter, equally stunning neighbor just next door: Bai Tu Long Bay. After experiencing both, I can confidently say this is the secret spot you'll want to choose, especially if you're traveling as a family.

After backpacking through Vietnam 12 years prior and experiencing a very cold and foggy Ha Long Bay (I had been February, after all) I was AMAZED to see what I'd missed last time. We spent three days and two nights aboard the Dragon Legend, one of Indochina Junk's luxury vessels, and it was easily one of the most unforgettable travel experiences we've ever had.

Bai Tu Long Bay looks identical to Ha Long in northern Vietnam, with jade-green water and dramatic cliffs rising straight from the sea, but it's blissfully uncrowded. Most boats stick to Ha Long's main routes, leaving Bai Tu Long quiet and pristine. That sense of stillness was what made it feel so special. It was the perfect way to wrap up our 5-day trip to the north of Vietnam with our toddler.

As our boat glided through the misty morning light, with nothing but the sound of the waves and birds overhead, I couldn't believe how few other ships we saw. It truly felt like we had the bay all to ourselves.

The Dragon Legend is beautiful, traditional in design with warm wood interiors and modern comforts. Our cabin was surprisingly spacious, complete with a king bed, a large window overlooking the water, and a soaking tub that framed the limestone cliffs perfectly.

The boat even has a shallow pool on deck, which turned out to be a huge hit with our son. Between dips in the pool and gazing out at the passing islands, he was completely content.

The staff went above and beyond to make us feel welcome, anticipating our needs before we even voiced them. They were especially wonderful with kids, patient and kind, and always finding ways to make the experience fun and memorable.

Each day brought new adventures, from kayaking through hidden lagoons to swimming in calm coves and visiting a local floating fishing village. But the moment that will forever stay in my heart was our private beach barbecue on a secluded island.

As the sun dipped behind the limestone cliffs, the crew set up a long table in the sand with flickering lanterns, grilled seafood, and cold drinks. Our son ran barefoot along the water's edge while we ate under the stars. It felt cinematic, simple yet extraordinary.

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Meals on board were just as memorable. The chefs managed to turn every meal into a multi-course event with Vietnamese specialties and fresh seafood that rivaled anything we've had on land.

Cruising Bai Tu Long Bay on the Dragon Legend offered the perfect mix of relaxation and exploration. The pace was easy, with plenty of downtime between excursions, and the small group size made it feel intimate.

Our son loved the freedom to explore the boat, splash in the pool, and join us on short, easy kayaking trips. We loved the comfort, the quiet, and the care that went into every detail.

If you've ever dreamed of seeing Ha Long Bay, choose Bai Tu Long instead. The views are just as magical, but the experience is infinitely more peaceful.

After three days of drifting through this dreamlike landscape, we left feeling completely renewed and already planning to return one day.

If you'd like to add Bai Tu Long Bay to your Vietnam itinerary, Muse Bespoke Escapes can seamlessly weave it in, pairing your cruise with a stay at Capella Hanoi for the perfect blend of culture, comfort, and quiet adventure.

\*Big thank you to Indochina Junk for hosting us on this cruise. All thoughts of the amazing experience are my own.

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## “The Forsyte Saga” is about hot men and the money they love

Melanie McFarland · Salon

What is a Forsyte? Lots of people may ask this question as excitement or dread builds around the PBS debut of “The Forsytes.” That excitement is because it is one of those titles that quietly shaped every period drama and miniseries that came after it.

The dread comes from fears of a reinterpretation of John Galsworthy’s Nobel Prize-winning books, collectively known as “The Forsyte Saga,” to suit an audience besotted with “Bridgerton” and other sensual period adaptations. Still, most who try to define a Forsyte do so because they aren’t familiar with these stories. At least, not in book form.

That benign ignorance will serve PBS’ highly liberal adaptation of the series very well.

“The Forsytes” is inspired by Galsworthy’s family of extremely wealthy stockbrokers in late-Victorian London, an age in which nobility’s influence and social dominance receded with the rise of new money. Nominally headed by its matriarch, Ann Forsyte (Francesca Annis), the series looks at how the overwhelming expectations of the older generation, led by Ann’s two ornery middle-aged sons, bring strife on their offspring.

Jolyon (Danny Griffin) is expected to assume leadership of the family firm, per tradition. But his uncle sees Jolyon as too soft to keep the firm competitive, believing his own son Soames (Joshua Orpin) to be a more suitably hard-nosed successor.

Sounds like “The Gilded Age,” right? That it does, which is why these books have been unearthed from the stacks yet again. “The Forsytes” is a clunky visual feast, but it’s also a new hot dish in an expanding buffet of eat-the-rich takes that materializes what one imagines a serialized adaptation of Gentlemen’s Quarterly would look like.

Galsworthy’s stories always had suds around the edges, but these new episodes are also a good deal hornier. Jolyon is played by a male model whose lustrous mane gets more of a workout than his emotional range. His character also boxes, preferring to spar shirtless.

Meanwhile, Orpin’s muscular flexing in Soames’ fitted T-shirts rivals anything Jeremy Allen White serves in “The Bear.” Even their rich daddies (played by Stephen Moyer and Jack Davenport) can still get it. Doubt me? Compare them to the grizzled, huffy statesmen who previously played those roles, especially in the 2002 ITV adaptation. Seriously, see for yourself — it’s currently streaming on Netflix. Unless you have a kink for Milburn Pennybags, aka the Monopoly man, my opinion stands.

Debbie Horsfield, who made millions swoon with “Poldark” before taking on this adaptation for PBS, recognizes the place that “The Forsyte Saga” holds in TV history. Every miniseries and period piece that came after the 1967 adap-

tation looks and feels the way they do because of what that series achieved. It brought the bootstrapping fantasy of this rising family, a few generations removed from the toiling class, into Britain’s living rooms with the right blend of serious theatricality and soapy splendor.

But the sensibilities of corset-and-bustle dramas have vastly changed since the first “Forsyte Saga” enthralled 18 million U. K. viewers nearly 60 years ago. (Once the world got in on the phenomenon — including, in a historic first for the BBC, the Soviet Union — viewership swelled to an estimated 160 million.)

style=“text-align: center;”> Want more from culture than just the latest trend? The Swell highlights art made to last.

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From age to age, defining what makes a Forsyte has grown trickier. Galsworthy’s heroes represent the way new money can be trapped between stifling tradition and modern realities, but our social boundaries are constantly shifting. And while previous TV adaptations root into the emotional interiority of their male characters while sidelining female desire, “The Forsytes” places more narrative purpose in the hands of its women.

That idea starts with Ann Forsyte’s table-setting narration, a la Lady Whistledown in “Bridgerton.” But it also plays out in the storyline between Jolyon, the favorite son, and Louisa Byrne (“Poldark” star Eleanor Tomlinson), a figure from his bohemian past. Once upon a time, he lived out his starving artist fantasies abroad before putting that aside to join the family business. He pretends to be content with all the trappings of wealth, but Louisa’s accidental reemergence makes him question everything — including his otherwise happy union with his carefully chosen wife (Tuppence Middleton), who understands the Forsytes’ ambition better than he does.

While Jolyon is a central character in “The Forsytes,” Soames’ inner conflict is Galsworthy’s cynosure: He’s a man who prizes acquisition and possession to the extent that he cannot love. As he’s classically rendered, Soames verges on unpalatable.

That also makes him a challenge for any actor to take on. Errol Flynn’s rendition in 1949’s “That Forsyte Woman” is viewed as one of his best performances. Damian Lewis’ 2002 version, captured fresh off his career-making work in “Band of Brothers,” shivers with trussed-up desire gone spoiled and toxic. And yet, in the end, you can’t help but pity the man.

Orpin initially presents Soames as a dutiful son eager to live up to his father’s demanding expectations until he meets Irene Heron (Millie Gibson), a penniless beauty grieving her recently deceased father. Irene’s artistic ambition and free-spirited nature draw Soames to her. When he falls for her, he claims he’ll give up anything to be at her side.

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# Who is the Kimwolf Botmaster “Dort”?

BrianKrebs · Krebs on Security

In early January 2026, KrebsOnSecurity revealed how a security researcher disclosed a vulnerability that was used to build Kimwolf, the world’s largest and most disruptive botnet. Since then, the person in control of Kimwolf — who goes by the handle “Dort” — has coordinated a barrage of distributed denial-of-service (DDoS), doxing and email flooding attacks against the researcher and this author, and more recently caused a SWAT team to be sent to the researcher’s home. This post examines what is knowable about Dort based on public information.

A public “dox” created in 2020 asserted Dort was a teenager from Canada (DOB August 2003) who used the aliases “CPacket” and “M1ce.” A search on the username CPacket at the open source intelligence platform OSINT Industries finds a GitHub account under the names Dort and CPacket that was created in 2017 using the email address jay.miner232@gmail.com.

The cyber intelligence firm Intel 471 says jay.miner232@gmail.com was used between 2015 and 2019 to create accounts at multiple cybercrime forums, including Nulled (username “Uubuntu”) and Cracked (user “Dorted”); Intel 471 reports that both of these accounts were created from the same Internet address at Rogers Canada (99.241.112.24).

Dort was an extremely active player in the Microsoft game Minecraft who gained notoriety for their “Dortware” software that helped players cheat. But somewhere along the way, Dort graduated from hacking Minecraft games to enabling far more serious crimes.

Dort also used the nickname DortDev, an identity that was active in March 2022 on the chat server for the prolific cybercrime group known as LAPSUS\$. Dort peddled a service for registering temporary email addresses, as well as “Dortsolver,” code that could bypass various CAPTCHA services designed to prevent automated account abuse. Both of these offerings were advertised in 2022 on SIM Land, a Telegram channel dedicated to SIM-swapping and account takeover activity.

The cyber intelligence firm Flashpoint indexed 2022 posts on SIM Land by Dort that show this person developed the disposable email and CAPTCHA bypass services with the help of another hacker who went by the handle “Qoft.”

“I legit just work with Jacob,” Qoft said in 2022 in reply to another user, referring to their exclusive business partner Dort. In the same conversation, Qoft bragged that the two had stolen more than \$250,000 worth of Microsoft Xbox Game Pass accounts by developing a program that mass-created Game Pass identities using stolen payment card data.

Who is the Jacob that Qoft referred to as their business partner? The breach tracking service Constella Intelli-

gence finds the password used by jay.miner232@gmail.com was reused by just one other email address: jacobbutler803@gmail.com. Recall that the 2020 dox of Dort said their date of birth was August 2003 (8/03).

Searching this email address at DomainTools.com reveals it was used in 2015 to register several Minecraft-themed domains, all assigned to a Jacob Butler in Ottawa, Canada and to the Ottawa phone number 613-909-9727.

Constella Intelligence finds jacobbutler803@gmail.com was used to register an account on the hacker forum Nulled in 2016, as well as the account name “M1CE” on Minecraft. Pivoting off the password used by their Nulled account shows it was shared by the email addresses j.a.y.m.iner232@gmail.com and jbutl3@ocdsb.ca, the latter being an address at a domain for the Ottawa-Carleton District School Board.

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*“It’s a pretty hefty penny for a new front door,” the diss track intoned.*

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BrianKrebs

Data indexed by the breach tracking service Spycloud suggests that at one point Jacob Butler shared a computer with his mother and a sibling, which might explain why their email accounts were connected to the password “jacob-plugs.” Neither Jacob nor any of the other Butler household members responded to requests for comment.

The open source intelligence service Epieos finds jacobbutler803@gmail.com created the GitHub account “MemeClient.” Meanwhile, Flashpoint indexed a deleted anonymous Pastebin.com post from 2017 declaring that MemeClient was the creation of a user named CPacket — one of Dort’s early monikers.

Why is Dort so mad? On January 2, KrebsOnSecurity published The Kimwolf Botnet is Stalking Your Local Network, which explored research into the botnet by Benjamin Brundage, founder of the proxy tracking service Synthient. Brundage figured out that the Kimwolf botmasters were exploiting a little-known weakness in residential proxy services to infect poorly-defended devices — like TV boxes and digital photo frames — plugged into the internal, private networks of proxy endpoints.

By the time that story went live, most of the vulnerable proxy providers had been notified by Brundage and had fixed the weaknesses in their systems. That vulnerability remediation process massively slowed Kimwolf’s ability to spread, and within hours of the story’s publication Dort created a Discord server in my name that began publishing personal information about and violent threats against Brundage, Yours Truly, and others.

Last week, Dort and friends used that same Discord server (then named “Krebs’s Koinbase Kallars”) to threaten a swatting attack against Brundage, again posting his home address and personal information. Brundage told KrebsOn-

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# The Amex Platinum Card: Why It's Worth it

Kristin Addis · Be My Travel Muse

The American Express Platinum Card, often heralded as the epitome of luxury in the credit card world, comes with a hefty annual fee of \$895. This fee may seem huge, but for those who can leverage the card's extensive benefits, it more than pays for itself. There's a reason why I've held onto mine for five years and will continue to hold onto it for the future.

In this review, I'll dive deep into the perks that make the Amex Platinum Card a mainstay in my wallet, despite its cost. We'll also touch on the downsides, including the increasing crowding in airport lounges and the recent limitations on guest access.

(Some users report opening in different apps helps if at first you don't receive the offer).

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Currently the welcome offer is up to 175k through this referral link , which can go a long, long way. These points can be worth up to \$800 or more, depending on how they're redeemed.

For example, I flew in Singapore Airlines business class (how I find deals ) all the way from San Francisco to Bali for 107,000 miles, so the welcome offer got me much of the way there. Here's how to make the card perks make sense.

Select one airline each calendar year and receive up to \$200 in statement credits for eligible incidental charges (e.g., baggage fees, seat assignments, in-flight food/drinks).

Get up to \$300 in statement credits semi-annually (total \$600/year ) on prepaid Fine Hotels + Resorts or The Hotel Collection bookings through Amex Travel when you pay with your Platinum Card.

You still get access to the Global Lounge Collection — including Centurion Lounges, Priority Pass (enrollment required), and select partner lounges — plus Delta Sky Club access when flying Delta .

Receive up to \$209/year in CLEAR Plus credits (to help speed through airport security) when you pay with your Platinum Card — enrollment required.

A statement credit for Global Entry (\$100) or TSA PreCheck (\$85) application fees (every 4–4.5 years).

Receive \$15/month in Uber Cash and a \$20 bonus in December to use on Uber rides or Uber Eats in the U. S. (must add your Platinum Card to your Uber account).

Up to \$120/year in statement credits if you pay for an auto-renewing Uber One membership with your Platinum Card.

Fine Hotels + Resorts benefits (room upgrades when available, daily breakfast for two, early check-in/late check-out, unique property amenity) via Amex Travel bookings.

The Hotel Collection perks: \$100 hotel credit + room upgrade (when available) on 2-night minimum stays.

You can also apply for Marriott and Hilton status when you're a card holder, as well as Avis and Hertz.

These stack with the \$600 hotel credit above.

(Enrollment often required; must activate credits each year or quarter where applicable.)

Up to \$100/year (split \$50 Jan–June and \$50 July–Dec) for purchases at Saks Fifth Avenue or Saks.com — no minimum purchase.

Up to \$100/quarter (total \$400/year) on eligible dining purchases through Resy.

Up to \$25/month (total \$300/year) for eligible digital entertainment services — now including Paramount+, YouTube Premium, and YouTube TV among others.

Up to \$75/quarter (total \$300/year) for eligible purchases at lululemon retail stores and [lululemon.com](https://lululemon.com).

Up to \$200/year in statement credits for purchases via Ōura Ring's official site.

Statement credits to cover one Walmart+ membership (up to \$12.95/month + tax) — must pay with Platinum Card. This also comes with a Peacock or Paramount+ subscription.

Up to \$300/year for Equinox club memberships or digital subscriptions.

Membership Rewards points transfer to many airline and hotel partners, often at a 1:1 rate — powerful for premium travel redemptions.

Trip cancellation/interruption insurance

Baggage insurance

Car rental loss/damage insurance

Purchase protections (varies by item and category) (These still apply but may have updated terms — always check Amex's Benefit Terms.)

Many credits (e.g., Resy, digital entertainment, lululemon, Ōura, Uber One) require enrollment and sometimes quarterly activation.

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## Weekly Review

Harper's Magazine · Harper's Magazine

The United States and Israel launched missile strikes against Iran, hitting military facilities, nuclear sites, ballistic-missile sites, and a girls' school, where at least 165 people, the vast majority of them children, were killed. 1 2 3 Iran's supreme leader was assassinated in the operation, news of which was confirmed by a post to his official X account depicting a robed warrior wielding a flaming sword. 4 "At some point they'll be calling me to ask who I'd like," the American president said when questioned about the supreme leader's replacement. "I'm only being a little sarcastic." 5 The president suggested that he launched the strikes, code-named Operation Epic Fury, partially owing to Iran's interference in his unsuccessful bid for the presidency in 2020, having made similar claims about Venezuela's government after the capture of that country's president earlier this year. 6 "Feels like déjà vu," an Iraq War veteran said of Epic Fury. 7 "We have to avoid over-learning the lessons of the past," said the vice president. "Just because one president screwed up a military conflict doesn't mean we can never engage in military conflict again." 8 The American president said it was "likely" that U. S. service members would die during the ongoing conflict in the region; Israel bombed southern Lebanon, killing at least thirty-one people; the Houthi militia in Yemen indicated that it would resume its attacks on U. S. and Israeli ships in the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden; three U. S. fighter jets were shot down by friendly fire in Kuwait; the managing director of a British travel insurance agency explained to stranded United Kingdom nationals that most policies do not cover war or "large-scale conflict events"; and a luxury hotel in Dubai was engulfed in flames after the United Arab Emirates intercepted an Iranian missile. 9 10 11 12 13 14 At the Dubai Tennis Championships, the doubles final proceeded, and the Iranian soccer chief said his country's team "cannot look forward to the World Cup with hope." 15 16 "We didn't sleep a wink all night," said the Italian rapper BigMama, whose flight from the Maldives was rerouted to the Emirati desert. 17 Seventy-one minutes before news broke that the United States and Israel had struck Iran, a Polymarket user called "Magamyman" placed an \$87,000 bet on the strikes' taking place, in turn netting more than half a million dollars. 18

The American president banned government agencies from using products designed by the artificial-intelligence company Anthropic, and the secretary of war designated the company a "supply chain risk to national security" following the breakdown of negotiations regarding the use of the company's products to create fully autonomous weapons systems and the means for the mass-surveillance of American citizens. 19 20 21 Around five hours later, OpenAI, which has received some \$1 billion in funding from a venture-capital firm operated by the brother of the president's son-in-law and whose cofounder donated \$25 million to a pro-Trump super PAC earlier this year, announced it had signed a contract with the government. 22 23 24 25 It was reported that the U. S. military used Anthropic's

AI tool, Claude, in its strikes on Iran after the ban on the company had taken effect; and Claude overtook ChatGPT, OpenAI's product, as the bestselling chatbot on Apple's App Store. 26 27 The Trump Administration announced that it would withhold \$259 million in Medicaid funds from Minnesota, with the vice president saying that he was "quite confident that we have the authority to do this"; and the secretary of war accused the youth organization Scouting America, once known as the Boy Scouts of America, of being "anti-American." 28 29 "I've heard a lot of dumb stuff," a Republican congressman said in response, "but this is up there." 30

The Bolivian military dispersed a mob of hundreds from the crash site of an Air Force plane that had been carrying newly printed banknotes, and the American military used a laser to shoot down a drone operated by the country's own Border Patrol. 31 32 The English rock band Radiohead demanded that Immigration and Customs Enforcement remove one of the band's songs from a promotional video, telling the "amateurs" at the agency to "go fuck yourselves"; and Chicago residents voted to name a municipal snowplow "Abolish ICE." 33 34 An Australian grocery chain tinkered with its AI assistant after the technology repeatedly complained about its mother; Burger King announced that it would debut an AI agent, to be programmed into workers' headsets, that will collect data on their "friendliness"; and a Spanish software engineer accidentally hacked into seven thousand vacuum cleaners. 35 36 37 It was reported that callers to the Washington State Department of Licensing who had selected the Spanish-language service were patched through to an AI speaking Spanish-accented English. 38 The pope urged priests not to use AI when writing their homilies. 39 A woman who is on probation for sneaking onto a flight to Paris last year was arrested for stowing away on a flight to Milan. 40 A Turkish soccer match was paused so that a player could perform CPR on a seagull that had been struck by a kicked ball. 41 "We missed out on the championship," said the player, "but helping save a life is a good thing." 42 —Megan Evershed

The post Weekly Review appeared first on Harper's Magazine .

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# Funniest/Most Insightful Comments Of The Week At Techdirt

Leigh Beadon · Techdirt

This week, our first place winner on the insightful side is Stephen T. Stone with a rebuke to someone defending the Fifth Circuit's ruling about whether a cop could sue Twitter :

By the logic of the Fifth Circuit's rulings, Donald Trump can and should be held responsible for the actions of the rioters on the 6th of January 2021. Is that the position you wish to take?

In second place, it's a long comment from Azuaron disagreeing with many parts of our post about the verdict against Meta :

Hold up

I don't wholly agree with this ruling or it's implications—The Encryption Problem, in particular, is a terrible argument that has to die—but I really have to address this section because it's not accurate:

The trial judge in the California case bought this argument, ruling that because the claims were about “product design and other non-speech issues,” Section 230 didn't apply. The New Mexico court reached a similar conclusion. Both cases then went to trial.

This distinction — between “design” and “content” — sounds reasonable for about three seconds. Then you realize it falls apart completely.

Here's a thought experiment: imagine Instagram, but every single post is a video of paint drying. Same infinite scroll. Same autoplay. Same algorithmic recommendations. Same notification systems. Is anyone addicted? Is anyone harmed? Is anyone suing?

Of course not. Because infinite scroll is not inherently harmful. Autoplay is not inherently harmful. Algorithmic recommendations are not inherently harmful. These features only matter because of the content they deliver. The “addictive design” does nothing without the underlying user-generated content that makes people want to keep scrolling.

Instagram has, I'm sure, thousands of videos of paint drying that, I'm also sure, have very few views. Those videos have very few views because part of Instagram's algorithmic recommendation system is to not serve videos of paint drying to people, because the design goal of Instagram is maximum addiction and use, which would not happen if their algorithm only recommended videos of paint drying.

The scenario of “Instagram, but with videos of paint drying. Same infinite scroll. Same autoplay. Same algorithmic recommendations. Same notification systems,” is the scenario we're in now where we do have people addicted, we do have people harmed, and people are suing. Constraining Instagram to have “only” videos of paint drying is a straw man

because it nearly eliminates all the design decisions that caused the harm. So, yeah, if you eliminate all that design that causes harm, the harm isn't caused, but that's not what anyone's talking about.

First, however, let's start with what Section 230 actually says:

No provider or user of an interactive computer service shall be treated as the publisher or speaker of any information provided by another information content provider.

No provider or user of an interactive computer service shall be held liable on account of—

(A) any action voluntarily taken in good faith to restrict access to or availability of material that the provider or user considers to be obscene, lewd, lascivious, filthy, excessively violent, harassing, or otherwise objectionable, whether or not such material is constitutionally protected; or

(B) any action taken to enable or make available to information content providers or others the technical means to restrict access to material described in paragraph (1).

There's more that I believe isn't currently relevant, but by all means look and correct me .

In every day language, what does 230 say? It's a narrow carve out for responsibility based only on “providers are not necessarily publishers” and “providers can choose what content appears, or does not”.

Now, what are these lawsuits claiming? They claim (I'm going to speak to just Instagram here, but this applies to all the others as well):

That Instagram, as a system, has been specifically designed to be addictive

That Instagram, as a system, has been specifically designed to worsen the mental health of its users

That Instagram, as a system, has been specifically designed to maximize user engagement at the expense of that user

That children deserve additional protection—just like children get additional protection from advertisement—from hostile systems because their brains are still developing and they're particularly vulnerable to it

None of those are content arguments, and saying, “But what if the content was paint drying?” is not relevant or helpful. People aren't addicted to “a single Instagram video” or even “a single Instagram channel” (you can probably tell I'm not on Instagram; I'm sure they're not called “channels”). People are addicted to the system of Instagram that feeds them content specifically tailored to maximize addiction and use, and feeds them content in a way that maximizes addiction and use. For some people that's makeup videos, for some people that's movie clips; the specific content is not the point. Hell, there's probably one guy in Minnesota

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# Trump's politics of death extend far beyond Iran

Chauncey DeVega · Salon

Going to war should be one of the most difficult decisions a president can make. People will die. That is the very definition of war. But instead of acting with gravitas following his choice to start a war with Iran, Donald Trump and his administration have celebrated the killing and devastation.

In comments to reporters at his Miami resort on March 9, nine days after the war began, the president raised the possibility of all but destroying Iran if they don't "behave." He boasted about killing their "sick," "crazy" and "demented" leaders, calling it "a great honor."

According to CNN, more than 1,300 Iranians have been killed. At least 3,000 people have died across the region. More than three million Iranians have been displaced by the war. Thirteen American service members have been killed, with more than 200 wounded, and the Pentagon is apparently considering sending more troops to the Middle East.

When asked about the American casualties, Trump has shown little emotion or concern. "We expect casualties," he said, "but in the end it's going to be a great deal for the world." His lack of respect extended to the dignified transfer of remains ceremony at Delaware's Dover Air Force Base where, as the flag-draped coffins of the first six dead were carried past him, he failed to remove his cap. Worse yet, with "USA" on the brim and "45-47" on the side, it promoted his own presidency and is listed for sale in his online store. Now a political action committee linked to Trump has used a photo of him saluting the coffins in a fundraising email.

But it's not just the president. The callousness extends to his entire administration. Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth is reveling in his role as a de facto warlord, declaring that the U. S. should give "no quarter, no mercy to our enemies." That statement is particularly concerning. Taken to its logical end, it would endorse the killing of wounded and surrendered enemy forces, which is a war crime under the Geneva Conventions. This possibility isn't far-fetched; Hegseth does not believe in the rules of engagement.

The Pentagon and White House are also creating official propaganda reels that depict the war as a video game, or a Hollywood action movie akin to something we would see in "Starship Troopers" or "RoboCop."

Military veterans and other professionals are disgusted by these propaganda videos. "It just seems detached from reality," Lt. Gen. (Ret.) Ben Hodges, former commander of U. S. Army forces in Europe, told POLITICO. "Our allies look at this, and they wonder, what the hell is going on? It doesn't look like we're serious."

Dr. Gary Slutkin, former head of the World Health Organization's Intervention Development Unit and author of the new book "The End of Violence: Eliminating the World's Most Dangerous Epidemic," warns that Trump's cal-

lousness about violence is a function of a "disease" infecting our government and culture.

"What we are watching from this administration in Iran is not just a lack of strategy, recklessness or incompetence," he said in an email. "As someone who has spent decades studying how violence spreads, I recognize it as something more specific: what I have come to call authoritarian violence disorder. Violence is a disease, with characteristic signs and symptoms that cause disability and death. But AVD is the most lethal form, distinguished by its scale, its cruelty, and its potential for mass death."

While the Trump administration's gleeful response to death and destruction in the war against Iran is obscene, it shouldn't come as a surprise. American conservatism and the broader right have cultivated a culture of violence and death for more than a century.

While the Trump administration's gleeful response to death and destruction in the war against Iran is obscene, it shouldn't come as a surprise. American conservatism and the broader right have cultivated a culture of violence and death for more than a century. Trump's embrace of cruelty as official policy, both at home and abroad, is the distillation of those values and forces.

Social scientists have repeatedly documented that Republican and conservative policies across a range of issues are correlated with higher rates of measurable harm and negative outcomes to public safety, health and well-being. As psychiatrist James Gilligan argues in his book "Why Some Politicians Are More Dangerous Than Others," this dynamic is greatly amplified when the GOP holds the presidency.

The damage is not abstract. A 2021 Lancet report estimated that approximately 461,000 excess deaths resulted each year from the first Trump administration's policies — and that was before the Covid-19 pandemic. Other research has found that failures by the Trump administration and Republican leaders at the state level contributed to around one million excess deaths during the pandemic.

Trump's second term has continued this pattern of death. Researchers at Yale University and the University of Pennsylvania estimate that the president's so-called One Big Beautiful Bill, with its cuts to health care, housing and the social safety net, could kill more than 51,000 Americans annually. A new report from the American Journal of Respiratory and Critical Care Medicine projects that the administration's rollback of environmental regulations, vaccination requirements and workplace safety rules will produce millions of additional deaths from respiratory illness in the coming years.

The harm extends far beyond America's borders. In the next four years, an estimated 15 million people will die because of the administration's cuts to humanitarian aid. A disproportionate share of them will be children.

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# Surfshark VPN review: Affordable protection with solid performance

Tyler Cooper · Salon

If you're searching for a VPN that won't break the bank but still delivers the goods, Surfshark deserves your attention. Founded in 2018, this relatively young player has quickly made waves in the crowded VPN market by offering unlimited simultaneous connections, strong privacy features and competitive pricing.

It's particularly appealing to households or users with multiple devices who want comprehensive protection without juggling multiple subscriptions. While it is newer to the market, Surfshark has built a solid reputation for delivering reliable performance and genuinely useful features that go beyond basic VPN functionality.

## Company background

A team based in the British Virgin Islands founded Surfshark in 2018. The company is now officially registered in the Netherlands. In 2022, Surfshark merged with Nord Security, the parent company behind NordVPN, creating a larger entity while maintaining separate operations and product identities. This merger raised some eyebrows in the privacy community, but both services continue to operate independently with their own infrastructure.

From a privacy jurisdiction standpoint, the Netherlands offers a mixed bag. While it's part of the EU and subject to GDPR regulations (which is generally positive for user rights), it's also within the Nine Eyes intelligence-sharing alliance. However, Surfshark maintains that it operates under a strict no-logs policy, meaning there's theoretically nothing logged at all from your session while connected. The British Virgin Islands registration for the original founding provides an additional layer of separation from intrusive data retention laws.

## Key features and technology

Surfshark is technically well-equipped. The service uses AES-256-GCM encryption, which is industry standard and essentially uncrackable with current technology. For protocols, you get a solid selection: WireGuard (the fastest and most modern option), OpenVPN (the tried-and-true standard) and IKEv2 for mobile devices.

The core security features are all present and accounted for. The kill switch automatically cuts your internet connection if the VPN drops, preventing any accidental data leaks. Split tunneling (called Bypasser in Surfshark's interface) lets you route some apps through the VPN while others use your regular connection—handy if you need to access local services while staying protected. The MultiHop feature routes your connection through two VPN servers instead of one, adding an extra layer of obfuscation for maximum privacy.

For those in restrictive regions, Surfshark includes Camouflage Mode (obfuscation) that disguises VPN traffic as regular HTTPS traffic, making it harder for ISPs or governments

to detect and block. DNS leak protection is built-in, and there's also CleanWeb, Surfshark's ad and malware blocker that works system-wide.

Where Surfshark really stands out is in its value-added features. You get Surfshark Search, a private search engine with no ads or tracking, Surfshark Alert for data breach monitoring, and Alternative ID for generating fake personal details for online registrations. For an additional fee, you can add Surfshark Antivirus and Alternative Number for disposable phone numbers. Dedicated IP addresses are also available as an add-on if you need a consistent IP for accessing work networks or avoiding CAPTCHAs.

## Infrastructure and server network

Surfshark operates over 3,200 servers across 100 countries, which is impressive coverage for a service at this price point. The company has transitioned to 100% RAM-only servers (they call them "diskless servers"), which means no data persists on the hardware once it's powered down. This is generally regarded as a significant privacy upgrade that only a handful of premium VPNs offer.

The network includes a mix of physical and virtual server locations. While Surfshark hasn't been entirely transparent about which specific locations are virtual, they've acknowledged using virtual servers in countries where physical infrastructure isn't feasible or safe to operate. Most servers support P2P traffic, and there are no bandwidth limits, making Surfshark a solid choice for torrenting.

## Apps and usability

Surfshark covers all the major platforms: Windows, macOS, Linux, iOS, Android, Fire TV and Apple TV. There are also browser extensions for Chrome, Firefox and Edge. You can even set it up on routers, gaming consoles and smart TVs, though that requires a bit more technical know-how.

The apps are genuinely user-friendly with a clean, modern interface that's consistent across platforms. The setup process is refreshingly simple—download, log in and hit the Quick Connect button. That's it. For tech-savvy users, there's a wealth of advanced settings tucked away in the menu, including protocol selection, kill switch customization and split tunneling rules.

One nice touch is the ability to create shortcuts to specific locations or features right on your home screen. The mobile apps include a GPS spoofing feature (Android only) that changes your device's GPS location to match your VPN server, which is useful for location-based apps.

## Performance and speed

Here's where Surfshark truly stands out. We conducted speed tests across multiple times of day and different server locations to get a realistic picture of Surfshark's performance.

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## Juvenile Impulse

Becky Zhang · Harper's Magazine

Nell Freudenberger's fiction has spanned settings as far-ranging as Southeast Asia, the Indian subcontinent, French Polynesia, and New York City. Across these landscapes and throughout her four novels and short story collection, *Lucky Girls*, which received the PEN/Malamud Award and the Sue Kaufman Prize for First Fiction, she has shown herself to be a keen observer of the fissures and convergences between cultures near and far, the power dynamics that shape communities, and the trespasses and intimacies that form across these gaps.

Freudenberger's story in the February 2026 issue, "The Precipice," follows a middle-aged woman recounting the trials of her all-girls high school's literary magazine, which was presided over by two male English teachers. The Arden School for Girls, with just sixty students per grade, attempts to transpose East Coast rigor onto the languorous climate of southern California, instituting high academic standards and following a fixed social hierarchy. As they approach adulthood amid the school's "impossible contradictions," the students find themselves caught between abstract freedoms and concrete rules. Recollecting this period, the narrator confronts anew the questions she and her peers had unknowingly addressed—those of selfhood, desire, and authorial agency.

Becky Zhang: "The Precipice" is set at a private all-girls school in Los Angeles in the Nineties, but is written from the perspective of a woman in the present looking back on that time in her life. Why did you choose to cast the story in a retrospective frame?

Nell Freudenberger: I don't usually write in the first person, or from a perspective this close to my own. What prompted this story was thinking about the ways my kids' school experiences are different from the one I had. Sometimes their dad or I will mention a memory that shocks them: the pipe bomb that exploded in the bathroom of his public junior high school in Birmingham, Michigan; or the teacher who called students at my private high school by derogatory nicknames based on race or ethnicity. I hope that the examples of flagrant racism and the sexual relationships between teachers and students in this story would be impossible, or at least much less likely, today, but those are familiar stories.

What really interested me was the way that memories are interconnected; once you start writing about the past, details that you couldn't have remembered in a vacuum occur to you, and people and events snap into focus. These newly remembered events, from our current vantage, appear utterly different than they did at the time.

Zhang: The two English teachers in this story—Wheeler and Boyd, as they are called by their students—are each other's foils: Wheeler is tall, Boyd is short; Wheeler is prim, Boyd is unkempt; Boyd uses overhead lighting in his classroom,

while Wheeler prefers the light of three "mismatched" lamps. I wondered whether their differences were as pronounced as they seem to be for the narrator, or whether they might be inflated by memory.

Freudenberger: I actually do think of them as quite different. They're men of the same generation, and they may have made some of the same mistakes, though that doesn't excuse them. I don't think Boyd would have been especially progressive regarding race, for instance. As a young woman, though, I remember thinking that I met two types of older men: one type thought of girls and women as potential conquests; the other, much rarer type thought of us as individuals. Boyd belongs to the second category, and for that reason his impact on some of the girls he teaches is profound.

Zhang: Wheeler and Boyd seem to pay tribute to the archetype of the charismatic, unorthodox teacher (I'm thinking of Muriel Spark's *The Prime of Miss Jean Brodie* and Mr. Keating from *Dead Poets Society*) while coming to life as distinct personalities of their own. Were there literary precedents you had in mind while creating their characters?

Freudenberger: I have to admit: I loved school, and I still love reading about it. George Orwell's essay "Such, Such Were the Joys" made a huge impression on me as a teenager (and makes the Arden School look fairly tame). John Williams's *Stoner*, Kazuo Ishiguro's *Never Let Me Go*, and Heather McGowan's *Schooling* are some others that come to mind, along with Donald Barthelme's great stories "The School" and "Porcupines at the University." But I wasn't thinking of any particular literary precedents when I was writing this story; I thought of the teachers I had and some I'd heard about, and those people together became Wheeler and Boyd.

Zhang: "The Precipice" takes place before the pervasiveness of the internet as we know it today. The narrator notes how, without access to Google or a smartphone in your hand, you simply didn't have the answers to most things back then. The story is also a *Künstlerroman*, in which the narrator gets closer to finding her voice as a writer. How did this particular time period inform the narrator's creative and intellectual growth?

Freudenberger: I'm going to go out on a limb and say that it was a lot easier to develop as a writer back then. Books, and especially poetry, were a more central part of the culture. Many of my classmates, even those who weren't that interested in English classes, read for pleasure. Obviously there was less to distract us. (Maybe if you were really procrastinating, you might chat with a friend for an hour on the newly cordless phone or read "It Happened to Me" in *Sassy* magazine.) At my school, we read mostly white European or American authors, so we missed out on a lot. We did read much more poetry than high school students seem to read today, and I remember loving *The Norton Anthology of Poetry* because it gave you a sense of how one generation of writers responded to another.

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# Streamlining Security Investigations with Agents

Dominic Marks · Slack Engineering

Slack's Security Engineering team is responsible for protecting Slack's core infrastructure and services. Our security event ingestion pipeline handles billions of events per day from a diverse array of data sources. Reviewing alerts produced by our security detection system is our primary responsibility during on-call shifts.

We're going to show you how we're using AI agents to optimize our working efficiency and strengthen Slack's security defenses. This post is the first in a series that will unpack some of the design choices we've made and the many things we've learnt along the way.

At the end of May 2025 we had a rudimentary prototype of what would grow into our service. Initially, the service was not much more than a 300 word prompt.

The prompt consisted of five sections:

style="font-weight: 400;"> Orientation : "You are a security analyst that investigates security alerts [...]"

style="font-weight: 400;"> Manifest : "You have access to the following data sources: [...]"

style="font-weight: 400;"> Methodology : "Your investigation should follow these steps: [...]"

style="font-weight: 400;"> Formatting : "Produce a mark-down report of the investigation: [...]"

style="font-weight: 400;"> Classification : "Choose a response classification from: [...]"

We implemented a simple "stdio" mode MCP server to safely expose a subset of our data sources through the tool call interface. We repurposed a coding agent CLI as an execution environment for our prototype.

The performance of our prototype implementation was highly variable: sometimes it would produce excellent, insightful results with an impressive ability to cross-reference evidence across different data sources. However, sometimes it would quickly jump to a convenient or spurious conclusion without adequately questioning its own methods. For the tool to be useful, we needed consistent performance. We needed greater control over the investigation process.

We spent some time trying to refine our prompt, stressing the need to question assumptions, to verify data from multiple sources, and to make use of the complete set of data sources. While we did have some success with this approach, ultimately prompts are just guidelines; they're not an effective method for achieving fine-grained control.

Our solution was to break down the complex investigation process we'd described in the prompt of our prototype into

a sequence of model invocations, each with a single, well-defined purpose and output structure. These simple tasks are chained together by our application.

Each task was given a structured output format. Structured output is a feature that can be used to restrict a model to using a specific output format defined by a JSON schema. The schema is applied to the last output from the model invocation. Using structured outputs isn't "free"; if the output format is too complicated for the model, the execution can fail. Structured outputs are also subject to the usual problems of cheating and hallucination.

In our initial prototype, we included guidance to "question your evidence", but had mixed success. With our structured output approach, that guidance had become a separate task in our investigation flow with much more predictable behavior.

This approach gave us more precise control at each step of the investigation process.

## From Prototype to Production

While reviewing the literature, two papers particularly influenced our thinking:

style="font-weight: 400;"> Meta-Prompting: Enhancing Language Models with Task-Agnostic Scaffolding (Stanford, OpenAI)

style="font-weight: 400;"> Unleashing the Emergent Cognitive Synergy in Large Language Models: A Task-Solving Agent through Multi-Persona Self-Collaboration (Microsoft Research)

These papers describe prompting techniques that introduce multiple personas in the context of a single model invocation. The idea of modelling the investigation using defined personas was intriguing, but in order to maintain control we needed to represent our personas as independent model invocations. Security tabletop exercises, and how we might adapt their conventions to our application, were also a major source of inspiration during the design process.

Our chosen design is built around a team of personas (agents) and the tasks they can perform in the investigation process. Each agent/task pair is modelled with a carefully defined structured output, and our application orchestrates the model invocations, propagating just the right context at each stage.

The Director agent poses a question and domain expert agents respond, generating findings. The Critic agent reviews findings for quality and assembles a timeline using the most credible. The Director uses the high-quality findings and timeline to determine how to progress the investigation.

Our design has three defined persona categories:

(Edited for length)

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# SCOTUS set to deal major blow to mail voting ahead of midterms

Jelinda Montes · Salon

In the 2024 election, nearly one in three Americans voted using mail-in or absentee ballots, accounting for some 48 million votes. And despite persistent rhetoric against it, even President Donald Trump votes by mail. Nevertheless, Trump further admonished mail voting while pushing the SAVE America Act, which could radically change how people vote ahead of the midterms. “Mail-in voting means mail-in cheating,” he said to press in Memphis, Tenn., Monday. “I call it mail-in cheating, and we got to do something about it all.”

Outside of the legislature, another body is doing something about mail ballots that may change how millions of Americans vote. The U. S. Supreme Court began oral arguments Monday on *Watson v. RNC*, a case determining if Mississippi allowing late mail-in ballots violates federal law establishing a specific election day. The largest question in this case is whether ballots need to be received by Election Day or just be cast by Election Day and allowed to be received later.

“I don’t think it’s a coincidence that you’re seeing the Trump administration talk about mail-in ballots in the SAVE Act at the same time that that case is going to be heard by the Supreme Court,” Travis Crum, an election law professor at the Washington University in St. Louis, said.

The Supreme Court seems poised to reject the Mississippi law based on oral arguments where justices were particularly incisive about the potential to recall a ballot and concerns of perceived fraud.

Washington, D. C. and 13 other states have similar laws to Mississippi in which ballots postmarked on or before Election Day will be counted within a certain period of time after Election Day. In Mississippi’s case, ballots can be received within five business days after the election so long as they’re sent by Election Day.

The Republican National Convention challenged this law in Mississippi, arguing it violates the 1845 Presidential Election Day Act that established a single election day as the Tuesday after the first Monday in November. They posit that Congress choosing one specific election day overrides a state’s ability to accept ballots afterward, even if they’re postmarked by Election Day.

“One of the interesting things here is we are debating the meaning of a law that was passed 180 years ago,” Michael Morley, the director of the Florida State University’s Election Law Center, said in an interview with Salon.

Morley, who filed a friend of the court brief in this case for neither party, argues that, in the modern day, no one reads the Presidential Election Day act literally. The law says Election Day is when each state shall appoint their electors for president and vice president, which is no longer done

on actual Election Day due to the amount of time it takes to process and organize ballots and electors.

“I think it’s pretty hard to argue that all of the election was happening on Election Day,” Morley said. He believes the Supreme Court needs to resolve the “vagueness and ambiguity” of the Election Day laws and possibly remand it back to a lower court before it can make a decision regarding the Mississippi late ballots law.

Others say history and the text are clear in demonstrating that Mississippi doesn’t violate federal law. Throughout this nearly two century period, Congress has not acted to prevent states from accepting Election Day postmarked ballots in the days following the election.

“There’s just no question that Congress has always been aware of the variability in state ballot laws and has never acted to disrupt that,” Anna Baldwin, the Campaign Legal Center’s director of voting rights litigation, told Salon. Campaign Legal Center also filed a friend of the court brief in the case, this time in support of Mississippi.

style="text-align: center;">"> Start your day with essential news from Salon.

“If Congress had wanted to make a change, where you would’ve expected them to say something about that, it would have been in Electoral Account Reform Act,” Baldwin said. “The fact that they didn’t just is even more evidence that they intended to maintain the status quo.”

style="text-align: center;">"> Start your day with essential news from Salon.

Jelinda Montes

The Electoral Count Account Reform Act of 2022 updated the 1887 Electoral Count Act, making clarifications around ambiguous language on the casting and counting of electoral votes. The law did not prohibit state statutes around ballot receipt deadlines. Another law, the 1986 Uniformed and Overseas Citizens Absentee Voting Act, allows for military and abroad citizens to vote. Twenty-nine states allow those absentee ballots to be postmarked and received after Election Day, and it is unclear if the case against Mississippi will affect these state laws and abroad voters.

Throughout the oral arguments, various justices brought up concerns about the potential for absentee voters to recall their ballots to change or alter them in some type of way. Common delivery services like UPS or FedEx typically allow users to recall mail they sent and have it returned to them. Baldwin argues claims around the possibility of recall are outlandish, but also something that the court shouldn’t be addressing.

“Mail voting law plays an important role for a number of constituencies, including military and overseas voters, and there’s just no valid reason based on fraud to limit it, and at any rate that’s a policy matter,” Baldwin said. “The Supreme

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# Tokyo Adrift

Matthew Sherrill · Harper's Magazine

Last year, a Japanese sumo wrestler named Onosato became the seventy-fifth athlete to be awarded the sport's highest honor: the title of yokozuna, or grand champion. His achievement was a particular cause for celebration among many Japanese sumo fans, given that the sport, despite its historical Japanese roots, has been largely dominated by Mongolian wrestlers for decades.

The fervor around Onosato, perhaps not incidentally, has coincided with the remarkable electoral success of Japan's far right. This has been best exemplified by Sanseito, an insurgent political party with a platform rooted in the demonization of immigrants at a time when Japan has a higher percentage of foreign-born residents than ever before.

In the March 2026 issue of Harper's Magazine, Joshua Hunt delves into the world of sumo—and the nationalist impulses it can inspire—in an attempt to take stock of contemporary Japanese identity. I spoke to Hunt recently about the national and international appeal of sumo wrestling, the success of Japan's anti-immigrant right, and why he, as a foreigner living in Tokyo, decided to leave the country behind.

**Matthew Sherrill:** At the core of your exploration of sumo is its status as Japan's "national sport." This is interesting to consider in light of the fact that baseball—"America's pastime"—is at this point considerably more popular in Japan. Yet sumo seems central to Japanese identity in a far more profound way. How would you describe the role that sumo plays in contemporary Japanese culture?

**Joshua Hunt:** Baseball does enjoy a much broader viewership than sumo in Japan, particularly when it comes to the national high school tournament known as Koshien. When the championship is on, it's rare to pass by a television set or radio that isn't tuned in. But sumo offers something much deeper, and I think even those who prefer baseball would tend to agree with this, in that it is distinctly Japanese. It has roots in Shinto religious practices that stretch back thousands of years, and in the hundreds of years since it transformed from a ritual into something more like a martial art or a sport, it has proven to be remarkably adaptable to the spirit of the times. One basic way of explaining how deeply Japan's most ardent sumo fans connect with their national sport is that very few contemporary rituals, not only in Japan, but anywhere, can claim such a direct connection with the founding myths of a nation and its people. To do that while also enjoying such mass appeal is truly remarkable.

**Sherrill:** When we first conceived of this piece, we talked principally about the dominance of Mongolian wrestlers and the challenge this has presented to certain varieties of Japanese nationalism. But I was shocked to learn through your reporting that there are professional sumo wrestlers of any number of ethnic and national backgrounds. In par-

ticular, you write about a Ukrainian wrestler who has been quite successful. Can you say more about how non-Japanese wrestlers find their way to sumo, and the particular hurdles or challenges they face as foreigners?

**Hunt:** Because Mongolia has become such a rich source of sumo talent, the country is home to a whole ecosystem of specialized "feeder" schools, sumo clubs, and recruiters focused on identifying young wrestlers. But wrestlers from countries like Georgia, Ukraine, or Romania tend to find their way to the sumo world by starting out in a Japanese martial art like judo, or another form of wrestling, then transitioning to sumo as a function of their physical attributes like physique, weight, and height.

The challenges that foreign wrestlers face are, in a way, not unlike those that any other immigrant faces in Japan, except that they are more extreme. In general, non-Japanese speakers are not coddled, and in a rigidly hierarchical sport like sumo, foreign recruits must prove themselves not only by winning but also by showing that they can adapt to both sporting and social rules and customs. Those who don't make an effort to learn at least very basic Japanese go nowhere. And because the life of a sumo wrestler is relatively communal, with most meals cooked and shared in the dormitories where those of the same wrestling stable live and train, they must adapt not only to a Japanese diet but to one developed especially for sumo; chanko nabe, for instance, a stew made with meat or fish and vegetables in a dashi broth, is the standard daily meal eaten by wrestlers, along with heaps of white rice. The hierarchy of the sumo stable also dictates that a rikishi—a professional wrestler—cook and clean for more senior wrestlers until he works his way up the sumo ladder. And these lower-ranked wrestlers not only do the cooking but also eat last. Depending on where a wrestler comes from, that can be tough to adapt to, and that's to say nothing of the vicious hazing and bullying scandals that emerge from time to time in the press.

**Sherrill:** As you were reporting this piece, Sanseito, a newly minted, far-right Japanese political party, enjoyed a surprise electoral victory, making the nationalist politics of sumo feel even more pertinent. What fueled the party's success? And how do the priorities of the far right in Japan differ from Trumpism and similar movements in the West?

**Hunt:** Record numbers of foreign tourists are visiting Japan (about forty-two million last year) and the country has more foreign residents than ever, forcing the Japanese public to come to terms with a change in what has traditionally been a relatively racially homogeneous society. Even though it's happening incrementally, the very fact that this kind of demographic change is taking place at a time when domestic-consumer spending power is down and that many parts of Tokyo feel like a playground for wealthy foreigners has put some wind in the sails of far-right parties like Sanseito. But there's still a pretty big divide between hardcore nationalism and what I would call a more diffuse sense of longing for those days when the yen went further and Tokyo felt a bit

less like a theme park. I would say that xenophobia in Japan tends toward the latter style, which is why I was attracted

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# Structure your Errors

Tikhon Jelvis

Recently, I've revisited how I represent errors in code.

I'm working on a command-line tool used across multiple teams and I want to keep its error messages consistent and readable. As the codebase has grown, I've moved from ad hoc error strings throughout my code to a structured error type.

I never want to see this in my software!

Useful error messages need to:

Contain the information and context to diagnose and fix the problem.

Provide an intuitive explanation for new users.

Format information consistently, in a way that's easy to scan at a glance.

We need 10–20 lines of code for each kind of error to generate error messages that fulfill these goals. In other projects, I would create error message strings directly in the code that first detected or raised an error, but that just does not scale here—it would add too much noise to my code! It's much harder to keep error messages consistent in style when they are so decentralized, and refactoring messages en masse becomes a nightmare.

To fix these problems, I've started using dedicated types for my errors. This took some up-front effort but has more than paid for itself over time; I've found this approach has a number of advantages on top of improving error messages and I'm going to lean towards this style in all my future projects.

What are structured errors?

When I talk about structured errors, I'm talking about how we represent the information attached to our errors rather than the control flow mechanism (like exceptions or monads) we use to handle them. When an error occurs, we assemble an object describing the error using actual values from the code—not just strings—giving us a structured representation of the error's context. Extracting specific pieces of information from an error should not take any parsing or guesswork!

If a function could fail because an API it depends on returned an HTTP error code, a structured error from that function would be a project-specific `ApiError` value carrying several pieces of information:

Which API failed.

The HTTP code it failed with.

The HTTP request that resulted in the failed response.

The HTTP response itself.

Additional data needed to provide context, like which inputs to the function caused the failure.

Contrast this with some less structured alternatives:

We could bubble up the error from our HTTP library.

But this lacks context specific to our application, which makes debugging harder. If our code called the same API in multiple places, how would we know which call led to the error?

We could produce a string: "API Foo v2 failed with HTTP 400."

But this is missing useful information—we need more details about exactly how the HTTP call failed—and the information it has is hard to extract.

How would we log or render the error in a different format? We would need to parse the details out of the string which would then break if we ever changed the text we're using—text that is ostensibly meant for humans to read!

We could ignore the HTTP error and let the code fail somewhere down the line.

I've seen this in real projects! This is how a logical API error turns into undefined is not a function. The only upside with this style is that you feel like a hero once you find where the error was actually coming from.

These alternatives might be easier to use up-front, but leaves us less information and flexibility in the future. It's a stock picture of technical debt: we're making our life marginally easier today in return for harder debugging and refactoring tomorrow.

At heart, this is a question of code architecture. Structured errors separate the code that produces errors from the code that handles them.

When we encounter a condition in our code that produces error, we do not need to worry about what happens afterwards or how the error information will be used. Will it be logged? Will it be displayed to the user as text? Will it be displayed in a UI widget? Will it be caught and handled silently without alerting anyone? We don't need answers to any of these questions; instead, we raise an error with all the context that we can and let downstream code handle it.

`id="error-messages">Error Messages`

The reason I started exploring this approach was to produce detailed, readable and consistent error messages. The logic to render error messages for the user doesn't have to fight for space and attention with domain-specific code; instead, it can be into a self-contained unit.

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# Build better software to build software better

David Reed (he/his) · Slack Engineering

We manage the build pipeline that delivers Quip and Slack Canvas's backend. A year ago, we were chasing exciting ideas to help engineers ship better code, faster. But we had one huge problem: builds took 60 minutes. With a build that slow, the whole pipeline gets less agile, and feedback doesn't come to engineers until far too late.

We fixed this problem by combining modern, high-performance build tooling (Bazel) with classic software engineering principles. Here's how we did it.

## Thinking About Build (and Code) Performance

Imagine a simple application. It has a backend server that provides an API and data storage, and a frontend that presents the user interface. Like many modern applications, the frontend and backend are decoupled; they can be developed and delivered independently.

The graph of this build looks like this:

We represent the dependencies between the elements of the build, like source files and deployable artifacts, with arrows, forming a directed acyclic graph. Here, our backend depends on a collection of Python files, meaning that whenever a Python file changes, we need to rebuild the backend. Likewise, we need to rebuild our frontend whenever a TypeScript file changes — but not when a Python file does.

Modeling our build as a graph of clearly-defined units of work lets us apply the same kind of performance optimizations we might use to speed up application code:

Do less work. Store the results of expensive work you do so that you only have to do it once, trading off memory for time.

Share the load. Spread the work you're doing across more compute resources in parallel, so that it completes more quickly, trading off compute for time.

## Caching and Parallelization

These techniques will look familiar to most engineers, and thinking about them through a code lens helps solidify how they apply to a build system. Take this Python example:

```
def factorial(n): return n * factorial(n-1) if n else 1
```

Calculating a factorial can be very expensive. If we need to do it often, we're going to run quite slowly. But intuitively, we know that the factorial of a number doesn't change. This means we can apply strategy 1 to cache the results of this function. Then it only needs to run once for any given input.

```
@functools.cache def factorial(n): return n * factorial(n-1) if n else 1
```

The cache stores our inputs (`n`) and maps them to the corresponding outputs (the return value of `factorial()`). `n` is the cache key: it functions like a source file in the build graph, with the output of the function corresponding to the built artifact.

Refining our intuition, we can say that this function needs to have a few specific attributes for caching to work. It needs to be hermetic: it only uses the inputs it is explicitly given to produce a specific output value. And it needs to be idempotent: the output for any given set of inputs is always the same. Otherwise, caching is unsound and will have rather surprising effects.

Once we have a cache in place, we want to maximize our hit rate: the fraction of times we call `factorial()` that are answered from the cache, rather than from doing the calculation. The way we define our units of work can help us keep the hit rate high.

To illustrate that idea, let's look at a more complex piece of code:

```
@functools.cache def process_images( images: list[Image], transforms: list[Transform] ) -> list[Image]: ..
```

This function has a cache attached to it, but the cache isn't very effective. The function takes two collections of inputs: a list of images and a list of transforms to apply to each image. If the caller changes any of those inputs, say by adding one more `Image` to the list, they also change the cache key. That means we won't find a result in the cache, and will have to do all of the work from the beginning.

In other words, this cache is not very granular, and as a result has a poor hit rate. More effective code might look like this:

```
def process_images( images: list[Image], transforms: list[Transform] ) -> list[Image]: new_images = [] for image in images: new_image = image for transform in transforms: new_image = process_image(new_image, transform) new_images.append(new_image)
```

```
return new_images
```

```
@functools.cache def process_image(image: Image, transform: Transform) -> Image: ...
```

We move the caching to a smaller unit of work — the application of a single transform to a single image — and with a correspondingly smaller cache key. We can still retain the higher-level API; we just don't cache there. When a caller invokes the higher-level API with a set of inputs, we can answer that request by only processing the combinations of `Image` and `Transform` that we haven't seen before. Everything else comes from the cache. Our cache hit rate should both improve, along with our performance.

Caching helps us do less work. Now let's look at sharing the load. What if we fanned out image processing across

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## Game Jam Winner Spotlight: I Am Sam Spade

Leigh Beadon · Techdirt

Last week, we announced the winners of our eighth annual public domain game jam, Gaming Like It's 1930! Now it's time to begin our series of spotlight posts, examining each of the winners in a bit more detail, and we're kicking things off today with a look at the winner of Best Adaptation: I am Sam Spade by Marshview Games .

A lot of people associate the hardboiled genre of detective fiction with the protagonist's inner monologue, as they ruminate on the situations that they face and give the reader a sense of their character and motivations. But some of the genre's foundational works, such as Dashiell Hammett's *The Maltese Falcon* , actually omit this entirely: the reader never sees inside detective Sam Spade's head, they only see what he does. *I am Sam Spade* by Marshview Games adapts this early classic while centering the later convention, with gameplay that focuses on the inner life of the detective to drive his actions, and puts players in his shoes. And not just one player, but all of them.

To do this, it borrows mechanics from Michael Sullivan's *Everyone Is John* , a classic in its own right. Two or more players become "Sams" — aspects of Sam Spade's personality, each with a pool of power and a specific skill, plus a core motivation that they will attempt to achieve. As the game master guides them through the events of *The Maltese Falcon* (or another detective story!), players bid their power to seize control of Sam Spade's actions. Though they must cooperate at least a little bit to make any progress, they are also in competition: the player whose motivations were most fulfilled by Sam wins the game.

The character of Sam Spade isn't a blank slate, but he is opaque, which makes getting inside his head the perfect starting point for reimagining the story, and *I am Sam Spade* puts this at the heart of its gameplay. For that, it's this year's Best Adaptation.

Congratulations to Marshview Games for the win! You can get everything you need to play *I am Sam Spade* from its page on Itch . We'll be back next week with another winner spotlight, and don't forget to check out the many great entries that didn't quite make the cut. And stay tuned for next year, when we'll be back for Gaming Like It's 1931.

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### ANALYSIS

# Microsoft Patch Tuesday, March 2026 Edition

Brian Krebs · Krebs on Security

Microsoft Corp. today pushed security updates to fix at least 77 vulnerabilities in its Windows operating systems and other software. There are no pressing “zero-day” flaws this month (compared to February’s five zero-day treat), but as usual some patches may deserve more rapid attention from organizations using Windows. Here are a few highlights from this month’s Patch Tuesday.

Two of the bugs Microsoft patched today were publicly disclosed previously. CVE-2026-21262 is a weakness that allows an attacker to elevate their privileges on SQL Server 2016 and later editions.

“This isn’t just any elevation of privilege vulnerability, either; the advisory notes that an authorized attacker can elevate privileges to sysadmin over a network,” Rapid7’s Adam Barnett said. “The CVSS v3 base score of 8.8 is just below the threshold for critical severity, since low-level privileges are required. It would be a courageous defender who shrugged and deferred the patches for this one.”

The other publicly disclosed flaw is CVE-2026-26127, a vulnerability in applications running on .NET. Barnett said the immediate impact of exploitation is likely limited to denial of service by triggering a crash, with the potential for other types of attacks during a service reboot.

It would hardly be a proper Patch Tuesday without at least one critical Microsoft Office exploit, and this month doesn’t disappoint. CVE-2026-26113 and CVE-2026-26110 are both remote code execution flaws that can be triggered just by viewing a booby-trapped message in the Preview Pane.

Satnam Narang at Tenable notes that just over half (55%) of all Patch Tuesday CVEs this month are privilege escalation bugs, and of those, a half dozen were rated “exploitation more likely” — across Windows Graphics Component, Windows Accessibility Infrastructure, Windows Kernel, Windows SMB Server and Winlogon. These include:

- CVE-2026-24291 : Incorrect permission assignments within the Windows Accessibility Infrastructure to reach SYSTEM (CVSS 7.8)
- CVE-2026-24294 : Improper authentication in the core SMB component (CVSS 7.8)
- CVE-2026-24289 : High-severity memory corruption and race condition flaw (CVSS 7.8)
- CVE-2026-25187 : Winlogon process weakness discovered by Google Project Zero (CVSS 7.8).

Ben McCarthy, lead cyber security engineer at Immersive, called attention to CVE-2026-21536, a critical remote code execution bug in a component called the Microsoft Devices Pricing Program. Microsoft has already resolved the issue on their end, and fixing it requires no action on the part of

Windows users. But McCarthy says it’s notable as one of the first vulnerabilities identified by an AI agent and officially recognized with a CVE attributed to the Windows operating system. It was discovered by XBOW, a fully autonomous AI penetration testing agent.

XBOW has consistently ranked at or near the top of the Hacker One bug bounty leaderboard for the past year. McCarthy said CVE-2026-21536 demonstrates how AI agents can identify critical 9.8-rated vulnerabilities without access to source code.

“Although Microsoft has already patched and mitigated the vulnerability, it highlights a shift toward AI-driven discovery of complex vulnerabilities at increasing speed,” McCarthy said. “This development suggests AI-assisted vulnerability research will play a growing role in the security landscape.”

Microsoft earlier provided patches to address nine browser vulnerabilities, which are not included in the Patch Tuesday count above. In addition, Microsoft issued a crucial out-of-band (emergency) update on March 2 for Windows Server 2022 to address a certificate renewal issue with passwordless authentication technology Windows Hello for Business.

Separately, Adobe shipped updates to fix 80 vulnerabilities — some of them critical in severity — in a variety of products, including Acrobat and Adobe Commerce. Mozilla Firefox v. 148.0.2 resolves three high severity CVEs.

For a complete breakdown of all the patches Microsoft released today, check out the SANS Internet Storm Center’s Patch Tuesday post. Windows enterprise admins who wish to stay abreast of any news about problematic updates, AskWoody.com is always worth a visit. Please feel free to drop a comment below if you experience any issues applying this month’s patches.

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8) – *CVE-2026-24294 : Improper authentication in the core SMB component*  
(CVSS 7.

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# Trump voters at CPAC unhappy about Iran, Epstein and economy

Alexander Hinton · Salon

There is a pall over the Make America Great Again, or MAGA, movement. Donald Trump overpromised. His public support has fallen. Some “America First” die-hards now openly criticize him.

Amid war, economic challenges, democratic backsliding, the Epstein files and Americans shot dead in the street by government agents, Trump’s support is softening and his vow to bring a “golden age of America” is looking more like a political winter for Trump and his MAGA movement.

This is my big takeaway from this year’s annual Conservative Political Action Conference, or CPAC. The event, organized by the American Conservative Union, launched with an international summit on March 25, 2026, and runs through March 28 in Grapevine, Texas.

Don’t get me wrong. The attendees are decked out in red, white and blue MAGA merch: sequined “Trump” purses and jackets, USA flag bags, ties and headbands, and, of course, iconic red MAGA caps. As always, they chant “USA,” even if not as often or as loudly as before.

Starting with the first talk by Rev. Franklin Graham, speakers here are still singing Trump’s praises. They underscore what they regard as major Trump 2.0 accomplishments: combating illegal immigration, cutting taxes, a budding economic boom, deregulation, U. S. gas and oil output surging, administrative state winnowing, pro-Christian policies and pulling the plug on the “woke” agenda.

These issues are foregrounded in sessions with titles like “Walls Work,” “Don’t Let Woke Marxists Raise Your Children,” “MAGA vs. Mullah Madness,” “Commies Go Home” and “Cancelling Satan.” In between, pro-Trump advertisements checklist Trump’s accomplishments.

This rose-tinted view is to be expected. After all, CPAC – a cross between a political rally, networking mixer and MAGA Comic-Con – is all about galvanizing the conservative base. Beneath the surface, however, MAGA is churning.

An attendee visits a stand at the Conservative Political Action Conference in Grapevine, Texas, on March 26, 2026.

Leandro Lozada/AFP via Getty Images

## Major grievances

An anthropologist of American political culture and author of the book “It Can Happen Here,” I have been studying MAGA for years and attending CPAC since 2023. Attendees at last year’s CPAC, held a month after Trump’s inauguration, were jubilant, with nonstop talk of “the comeback kid” and “the golden age.”

Why is the mood at this year’s CPAC more subdued?

Enthusiasm for Trump is dampened because some of his supporters feel he has betrayed America First principles, failed to fulfill key campaign promises and been unable to supercharge the economy. Here are their major grievances:

## ‘America First’ vs. ‘Israel First’

“America First” is the guiding principle of MAGA. It encompasses border security, prioritizing the U. S. economy and ensuring rights such as free speech. It also means avoiding unnecessary wars.

This is why Trump’s support of the June 2025 “12-day war” on Iran led Tucker Carlson, Marjorie Taylor Greene and other MAGA influencers, who have tens of millions of followers, to criticize Trump. The conflict, they contend, served Israel’s interest – their phrase is “Israel First” – not those of the U. S.

Their criticisms became even more pronounced after the U. S. again began bombing Iran on Feb. 28, 2026. The criticism is part of a growing MAGA fissure with pro-Israel stalwarts such as conservative activists Mark Levin, Laura Loomer and Ben Shapiro, who support U. S. intervention in the Middle East. Things got so bad that after Levin called his fellow conservative media personality Megyn Kelly “unhinged, lewd and petulant,” she dubbed him “Micropenis Mark.”

Former Proud Boys chairman Enrique Tarrio is seen at CPAC in Grapevine, Texas, on March 25, 2026.

Leandro Lozada/AFP via Getty Images

But the MAGA unease with the war extends well beyond the “America First” influencers.

It includes figures from the fringe far right such as provocateur Nick Fuentes, center-right “brocaster” Joe Rogan, and even the Trump administration itself – as illustrated by an intelligence officer whose resignation stated, “Iran posed no imminent threat to our nation, and it is clear that we started this war due to pressure from Israel and its powerful American lobby.”

Notably, none of the main Trump critics have been scheduled to speak at this year’s CPAC. Some now call it “TPAC,” or the Trump Political Action Conference.

## The Epstein files

MAGA also has a strong populist and anti-elite streak of conspiracy thinking.

Large numbers of Trump supporters, for example, believe there is an elite plot to what they call “replace” the white population with nonwhites through mass immigration. Many also bought into the QAnon conspiracy theory, which centers on the idea that Trump is fighting Satanic, deep state elites who are running a child sex trafficking operation.

On the campaign trail, Trump vowed to take down political, deep state and global elites. He also promised to release the

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# Hegseth's War On Anthropic Encounters The First Amendment

Cathy Gellis · Techdirt

The expression, “to make a federal case out of something” usually describes making a bigger deal out of something than it should be. But in the case of Anthropic and Hegseth, Trump, and the Department of Defense\*, this federal case is actually quite simple: what the government defendants did to Anthropic is beyond the bounds of anything the law or Constitution would allow. It didn't require some complicated analytical parsing to see the problem with the Administration's behavior, and the remedy is straightforward: there's now an injunction depriving that behavior of any effect (albeit stayed for seven days).

But the government is only restrained as to what it did that was actually illegal. Importantly, the injunction clarifies that to the extent that the government could lawfully stop working with Anthropic, it remained fully able to divorce itself. From the full paragraph on the last page of the preliminary injunction order itself articulating what has been restrained:

This Order restores the status quo. It does not bar any Defendant from taking any lawful action that would have been available to it on February 27, 2026, prior to the issuances of the Presidential Directive and the Hegseth Directive and entry of the Supply Chain Designation. For example, this Order does not require the Department of War to use Anthropic's products or services and does not prevent the Department of War from transitioning to other artificial intelligence providers, so long as those actions are consistent with applicable regulations, statutes, and constitutional provisions.

As the decision justifying the injunction explains, this case wasn't about whether and how DOD could use Anthropic and whether Anthropic could have a say in how it was used, which was the issue underpinning the contract dispute between the two. Had it been, then the DOD could have simply walked away from the product. The problem is that the government didn't just stop doing business with Anthropic; it went further, and it is those actions that broke the law.

The question here is whether the government violated the law when it went further. After Anthropic went public with its disagreement with the Department of War, Defendants reacted with three significant measures that are the subject of this lawsuit. First, the President announced that every federal agency (not just the Department of War) would immediately ban Anthropic from ever having another government contract. That would include, for example, the National Endowment for the Arts using Claude to design its website. Second, Secretary Hegseth announced that anyone who wants to do business with the U. S. military must sever any commercial relationship with Anthropic. That would mean a company that used Claude to power its customer service chatbot could not serve as a defense contractor. Third, the Department of War designated Anthropic a “supply chain risk,” a label that applies to adversaries of the U. S.

government who may sabotage its technology systems. That designation has never been applied to a domestic company and is directed principally at foreign intelligence agencies, terrorists, and other hostile actors. [p.1-2]

And the court counts several ways that the government's actions were likely illegal. At minimum, Anthropic suffered a due process violation for not having notice and an opportunity to respond to the government's sudden supply chain risk designation, which threatened a cognizable liberty interest the Fifth Amendment protects. (“The record shows that the Challenged Actions threaten to cripple Anthropic by not only stripping it of billions of dollars in federal contracts and subcontracts but also by labeling it as an adversary to the United States and ending its ability to have any commercial relationship with any company that might want to do business with DoW.”) [fuller analysis p.24-29]

The “supply chain risk” designation was also likely “both contrary to law and arbitrary and capricious.” On the first point, there are two statutory paths for designating a vendor a supply chain risk, and this case addressed just one of them—the other will be addressed by the DC Circuit. But it found the government's claim it was using the statutory authority properly to be wanting: First, Anthropic's conduct did not meet the statutory definition of a supply chain risk.

On the record before the Court, Anthropic's conduct does not appear to be within the definition of “supply chain risk” in Section 3252. Section 3252 defines a supply chain risk as limited to “the risk that an adversary may sabotage, maliciously introduce unwanted function, or otherwise subvert . . . a covered system.” 10 U. S. C. § 3252(d)(4). Assuming without deciding that a domestic company can be an “adversary,” the plain text of the statute is directed at covert acts or hacks, not overt positions taken during contract negotiations. Indeed, it is difficult to understand how one could sabotage, maliciously introduce an unwanted function, or subvert an information technology system by publicly announcing usage restrictions or insisting on such restrictions in conversations with DoW. Defendants appear to be taking the position that any vendor who “push[es] back” on or “question[s]” DoW becomes its “adversary.” (Dkt. No. 128 at 41.) That position is deeply troubling and inconsistent with the statutory text. [p.30-32]

And second, those procedural rules the government blew off to invoke the statute, such as the need to notify Congress first, actually mattered. Despite what the government argued at oral argument, that the Congressional notification requirements were only for the benefit of Congress, the court found that they were important safeguards Congress had built into the statute to prevent its abuse and therefore non-optional. (“Section 3252 and its enabling regulations create institutional safeguards—which the Secretary must complete before making a designation—to ensure that its designation is applied properly. The Supply Chain Designation failed to comply with these mandated procedural safeguards.”) [see analysis p.32-34].

(Edited for length)

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# What Is Employee Benefits Consulting and How Can It Benefit Your Business?

Susan Thompson · Small Business Trends

Employee benefits consulting is a strategic approach that helps businesses create customized benefits packages that meet both employee needs and organizational objectives. By partnering with experts, you can navigate complex compliance requirements, control costs, and improve employee engagement. This not merely boosts satisfaction and retention but furthermore cultivates a healthier workplace. Comprehending the nuances of these services can be essential for your business's success. So, how do you start finding the right consultant for your needs?

## id="key-takeaways">Key Takeaways

Employee benefits consulting tailors benefits packages to meet the unique needs of your workforce, improving employee satisfaction and retention.

Consultants ensure compliance with regulations like ERISA and ACA, minimizing legal risks for your business.

By analyzing claims data and market trends, consultants help control rising healthcare costs and implement effective risk management strategies.

Employee benefits consultants enhance communication and engagement, leading to higher utilization rates of benefits and improved workplace morale.

Customized benefits packages promote overall employee well-being, fostering a healthier, more productive work environment.

## id="understanding-employee-benefits-consulting-services">Understanding Employee Benefits Consulting Services

In regards to comprehending employee benefits consulting services, it's vital to recognize their significant role in shaping benefits programs that meet both employee needs and organizational objectives.

An employee benefits consultant analyzes your workforce's unique requirements, using data-driven approaches to design customized benefits packages. They guarantee compliance with regulations like ERISA and ACA, keeping you informed on any changes that could affect your offerings.

As an employee benefits broker, they additionally handle risk management by analyzing claims data for trends, helping you implement cost containment strategies without compromising the quality of benefits.

Effective communication is fundamental, and consultants provide solutions for branding and messaging to engage employees during open enrollment.

## id="the-role-of-an-employee-benefits-consultant">The Role of an Employee Benefits Consultant

During the process of maneuvering through the intricacies of employee benefits, comprehending the role of an employee benefits consultant is essential for organizations seeking to optimize their offerings.

Employee benefits consultants act as strategic partners, guiding you through the challenges of benefits packages customized to your company's objectives and employee needs. They provide year-round support, assisting with open enrollment and ensuring clear communication of benefits programs.

By analyzing claims data and market trends, these consultants help you control rising healthcare costs while ensuring compliance with regulations. They also cultivate relationships with insurance vendors, leveraging data for benchmarking and competitive analysis.

In addition, employee benefits brokers aid in developing funding strategies and risk management approaches, optimizing benefits administration while minimizing compliance risks and penalties.

Engaging an employee benefit brokerage can therefore improve employee satisfaction, retention, and overall organizational success.

## id="designing-customized-benefits-packages">Designing Customized Benefits Packages

When you design customized benefits packages, it's crucial to focus on your employees' unique needs and preferences.

By analyzing company demographics and gathering feedback through surveys, you can create offerings that resonate with your workforce at the same time as remaining cost-effective.

This approach not just improves employee satisfaction but furthermore helps you attract and retain top talent in a competitive market.

## id="tailored-employee-needs">Tailored Employee Needs

Customized employee needs play a crucial role in designing personalized benefits packages that not just attract talent but also improve retention. A benefits consultant can help you customize offerings to align with your workforce's specific requirements.

Here's how to get started:

Assess workforce demographics to understand employee preferences.

Utilize data-driven insights to identify trends in claims and usage.

Include a mix of health insurance, retirement plans, and wellness programs.

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# The Worst Years of Our Life

John R. MacArthur · Harper's Magazine

style="width: 250px; border: 1px solid black; background-color: white; margin-left: 30px; padding: 30px; padding-bottom: 30px; float: right; font-size: 90%;">A version of this column originally ran in *Le Devoir* on February 2, 2026. Translated from the French by Elettra Pauletto.

The unjust and brutal killing of Renee Nicole Good—a middle-class white woman—by a federal Immigration and Customs Enforcement agent in Minneapolis in early January occurred less than a mile away from where George Floyd—a poor black man—was unjustly and brutally murdered by a local police officer five years earlier. I wonder if the horrible parallel that connects them, in terms of geography and civic violence, is just a coincidence or whether the physical proximity of the murders betrays a fundamental shift toward a rupture in the collective fabric occurring between May 25, 2020 (during Trump's first term) and January 8, 2026 (during his second term), in a residential neighborhood south of Minneapolis, between 3757 Chicago Avenue (where Floyd was killed) and 3331 Portland Avenue (where Good was killed).

I'm talking about the rupture of a civilizing thread—historic events, like the start of the Civil War at Fort Sumter on April 12, 1861, the September 11 attacks in New York and Washington, and the assault on the Capitol on January 6, 2021, by pro-Trump rioters.

I'm not saying there is some obvious pattern in the link between these two parallel events. But ever since Donald Trump's inauguration in 2017, I've been making comparisons to the past, wondering if we're experiencing the worst years of our life as a nation. Have the pervasive resentment and social demoralization that characterize our cursed era—embodied by the grotesque reign of our mad king—reached the point of surpassing the worst upheavals of the 1960s and '70s, when we experienced one shock after another, with bodies piling up at the four corners of the continent, not to mention those amassing in Vietnam?

Will the rise of Trump and the Minneapolis martyrs bring about a similar shift? The assassination of John F. Kennedy in 1963 is often cited as a national turning point that marked the precipitous fall of the sacred American experiment—a kind of end of innocence. The young king turned away from paradise and cast into an uncivilized abyss. I have always considered this idea absurd. If America can still consider itself "innocent" after World War II, the Holocaust, and Hiroshima, then there is no such thing as historical meaning.

On the other hand, four events in 1968 might have acted as decisive turns for the worst. The Tet Offensive in Vietnam. The assassination of Martin Luther King, Jr., and the riots it triggered. The assassination of JFK's younger brother, Robert. And the police attack against anti-war protesters in Chicago during the Democratic National Convention. I remember the demoralization—dread, even—that shook seg-

ments of the population. The general sense of despair and national depression was reinforced by numerous deaths and hateful rhetoric from political figures like the racist governor George Wallace.

More than 2,600 American soldiers were killed within two days in the North Vietnamese army's ambush during the Tet holiday. King and Kennedy were gunned down and at least forty-three people died in the riots that erupted after King's death in Memphis. And then came the order from the then mayor of Chicago, Richard J. Daley, "to shoot to kill any arsonist or anyone with a Molotov cocktail," and "to shoot anyone looting stores in our city."

I'll never forget the devastating retort to this pro-Trump rhetoric from "the boss" of the second city. As Chicago police clubbed anti-war protesters in a public park, in full view of television networks, in the hall where the Democrats were choosing their next presidential candidate, senator Abraham Ribicoff denounced "Gestapo tactics in the streets of Chicago." Daley, standing in front of Ribicoff, rebuked him, but Ribicoff persisted, saying, "How hard it is to accept the truth."

This did not keep much of America from continuing to deny the truth about Vietnam. Ribicoff and others who supported peace were outnumbered by the Democratic party bigwigs (with Lyndon Johnson insisting on nominating Hubert Humphrey to the presidency). Unsurprisingly, his choice led to the election of Richard Nixon (a hidden hawk) in November 1968. Also unsurprisingly, on May 4, 1970, the Ohio National Guard shot and killed four young people protesting Nixon's order to invade Cambodia.

Of course, the Nixon-Johnson era caused far more American injuries and deaths (not even counting the millions of victims abroad) than the Trump era so far. In that sense, it's easy to say that those days were the "worst."

But the cynical politics of my youth—the enormous lie that was the war in Vietnam foremost among them—were counterbalanced by a genuinely moral, honest, and ethical movement (Ribicoff spoke on behalf of the famous antiwar senators, George McGovern and Eugene McCarthy). Today, Democratic party leaders parade their opposition to some new Trump indictment and deliver bland, inarticulate speeches in the face of the president's immorality and illegal conduct. Ironically, Joe Rogan, the usually pro-Trump right-wing podcaster, was the one who took up Ribicoff's voice and spirit after Renee Good was killed protesting the arbitrary arrest of undocumented immigrants, saying, "Are we really going to be the Gestapo?"

Both Johnson and Nixon eventually paid the price for their cynicism. But Trump seems to be getting away with murder every day he remains in power. And that is why we may feel that we are indeed experiencing the worst years of our life as a republic.

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# Iran is right: Trump has already lost this war

Andrew O'Hehir · Salon

More than 30 years ago, historian Eric Hobsbawm wrote that most young people in the late 20th century “grow up in a sort of permanent present lacking any organic relation to the public past of the times they live in.” (Apparently an “intelligent American student” had asked him whether the phrase “Second World War” meant that there had been a first one.)

That’s not the only moment in Hobsbawm’s 1994 book “The Age of Extremes” that now reads as uncanny. He also foresaw that the global victory of American-style capitalism in the Cold War was not the “end of history,” but contained the seeds of a coming global crisis, notably in the form of worsening inequality and a reversion to “barbarism.”

It might be foreshortening the narrative too much to say that those two observations explain where we find ourselves today, with another American president having ignored the most obvious possible lessons from history and blundered into another disastrous overseas military adventure, for even dumber and less comprehensible reasons than the last several times it happened. But it’s not wrong, either.

Donald Trump’s war with Iran marks his administration’s “looksmxing” moment: It’s preening before the mirror, repeatedly smashing itself in the face with hammers and launching banger memes, while aggressively pretending not to notice external reality, especially not the mockery, pity and terror it provokes in others. It now seems clear there was internal disagreement about launching this war in the first place, and that there’s now widespread internal bewilderment about how to end it.

Trump and Pete Hegseth and Marco Rubio and whomever else were lured into this war by Benjamin Netanyahu, pushed into it by the billionaire donors of the Israel lobby and, more than anything else, seduced into it by massive institutional incompetence and their thoroughly unfounded belief in their own awesomeness. As one Bluesky poster put it in early March, those guys believed they could wage and win a war easily just by being “based chads” (i.e., white dudes with retrograde attitudes about literally everything) who would avoid all the weak, woke, DEI-informed mistakes made in previous conflicts by such lily-livered libtards as, um, George W. Bush, Dick Cheney and Donald Rumsfeld.

Virtually no one in foreign policy circles, whether at think tanks or academic institutions and regardless of their position on the ideological spectrum, thought the U. S.-Israeli air war was likely to end the way Trump and Netanyahu wanted, presumably with a subservient new regime in Tehran. (It’s a well established military principle that air power can destroy cities and demoralize the civilian population, but it doesn’t win wars.) Of course the based chads of the Pentagon and White House and Fox News were sure they knew better than a bunch of Poindexters with fancy degrees and foundation grants. Now that the actual conflict

has gone almost as badly as it could have, its defenders have returned to their natural environment, cable TV, to conduct a rear-guard action aimed at swamping the American public in outlandish, boastful, prancing propaganda about “our” glorious victory, the one that has killed 1,500 civilians, cemented Iran’s surviving hard-liners in power, driven gasoline to \$4 a gallon (\$6 or more on the West Coast), cratered the stock market and spiked inflation.

class="insert-quote">Virtually no one in foreign policy circles thought the U. S.-Israeli air war was likely to end the way Trump and Netanyahu wanted. Of course the “based chads” of the Pentagon and White House and Fox News knew better than a bunch of Poindexters with fancy degrees.

Most Americans are understandably more concerned with those painful details than on the larger global picture, and may not care that this conflict has already resulted in world-historical humiliation on a scale likely to destroy the last shreds of America’s postwar reputation as an intermittently benevolent superpower. When *The Economist*, essentially the house organ of global capital, publishes an openly mocking cover illustration of a wartime U. S. president, the global zeitgeist has shifted gears. If it’s going too far to say that Iran is winning the war — the Iranian people certainly are not — the United States has already lost it.

No observer with a hint of objectivity can avoid the conclusion that the Iranian regime, for all its despicable qualities, has been a more reliable narrator during the course of this conflict than the U. S. government. An Iranian military spokesman taunted Trump last week, rejecting an American 15-point peace plan by asking: “Has the level of your inner struggle reached the stage of you negotiating with yourself?” Around the world, anyone who’s had dealings with our president recognized that as a clean hit.

As economics reporter Eduardo Porter writes in the *Guardian*, Trump’s “Persian TACO” pattern — the acronym stands for “Trump always chickens out” — that is, making extreme threats against Iran and then walking them back, may offer Trump “the illusion of agency,” but in fact “he no longer has control of events in Iran.” Despite the enormous damage and loss of life inflicted by the bombing campaign, the Iranians still control the Strait of Hormuz, retain most of their ballistic missile arsenal and have caused enormous economic disruption through attacks on neighboring Gulf states, a strategy U. S. and Israeli war planners did not foresee. Trump “does not get to decide when the conflict ends,” Porter concludes. “Markets are figuring out that that will probably be up to Tehran.”

Similarly, George Beebe and Trita Parsi of the Quincy Institute (a moderate think tank devoted to “responsible statecraft”) agree that “the war cannot end without Iran’s consent” and propose Vladimir Putin, of all people, as potential peacemaker, a notion so flat-out bananas that it might happen. (He’s the one world leader who’s close to the Iranian regime and also friendly with Netanyahu, who has conspicuously avoided taking sides in the Ukraine war.)

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## 7 Top Loyalty Program Platforms to Enhance Customer Retention

Linda Taylor · Small Business Trends

In today's competitive eCommerce environment, implementing a loyalty program can greatly improve customer retention. You need to contemplate platforms like Yotpo Loyalty, Loyalty Lion, and Smile.io, which offer customizable rewards and integration with existing systems. These platforms not just improve customer engagement through tiered rewards but furthermore provide analytics to track behavior. Comprehending the key features of these tools can help you make an informed decision that fits your business needs. What factors should you prioritize?

### id="key-takeaways">Key Takeaways

Yotpo Loyalty provides customizable programs with an integrated ROI dashboard, enhancing customer retention through tailored engagement strategies.

Loyalty Lion is designed for D2C e-commerce brands on Shopify, offering a user-friendly interface and flexible reward structures.

Smile.io is a plug-and-play solution ideal for small to medium-sized e-commerce businesses, featuring tiered rewards to encourage customer loyalty.

Okendo combines customer reviews with loyalty features, benefiting businesses by leveraging existing user feedback to enhance retention efforts.

Rivo specializes in Shopify-specific solutions, offering points and workflow automation to streamline customer engagement and retention initiatives.

### id="key-takeaways">Key Takeaways

When you consider implementing a loyalty program, it's vital to recognize the significant impact it can have on customer retention. A mere 5% increase in retention can lead to profit increases ranging from 25% to 95%.

When exploring loyalty program platforms, it's advantageous to choose those that align with your brand identity, like Yotpo Loyalty or LoyaltyLion, as they improve emotional connections with customers. Effective loyalty platforms often feature tiered structures, which encourage higher spending by offering escalating rewards based on customer loyalty.

Furthermore, robust analytics and reporting features are fundamental for tracking key performance indicators (KPIs) such as customer lifetime value and purchase frequency. This data justifies the return on investment (ROI) of your loyalty initiatives.

Companies like Smile.io and Okendo offer easy integration with eCommerce systems, ensuring seamless experiences across online and offline channels for increased customer

engagement, making them solid options for any CRM loyalty solutions company.

### id="why-your-ecommerce-business-needs-a-loyalty-platform">Why Your Ecommerce Business Needs a Loyalty Platform

Establishing a loyalty platform is crucial for your eCommerce business, as it greatly improves customer retention and drives profitability. A mere 5% increase in retention can boost profits by an impressive 25% to 95%.

Retaining existing customers is likewise considerably cheaper than acquiring new ones, with the latter costing five times more on average. Implementing an effective loyalty program nurtures emotional connections, turning customers into brand advocates who drive repeat purchases.

Furthermore, a well-designed platform improves brand trust and generates positive word-of-mouth marketing, attracting new customers organically. By offering customizable reward structures, robust analytics, and tiered programs, you can tailor loyalty initiatives to resonate with your target audience.

This adaptability guarantees that your loyalty program not just meets customer expectations but also aligns with your business goals, ultimately leading to sustained growth and increased profitability.

Investing in a loyalty platform is a strategic move for any eCommerce business aiming for long-term success.

### id="key-features-to-look-for-in-a-loyalty-platform">Key Features to Look for in a Loyalty Platform

When choosing a loyalty platform, you should prioritize customization options that let you align the program with your brand's identity. This includes tailoring colors, fonts, and logos to strengthen recognition and connection with your customers.

Furthermore, verify the platform integrates seamlessly with your existing systems, which will streamline operations and improve overall efficiency in managing customer interactions.

### id="customization-options-available">Customization Options Available

Customization options in loyalty program platforms are vital for creating a unique brand experience that resonates with your customers. You should look for platforms that allow you to incorporate your brand's colors, fonts, and logos, ensuring a cohesive presentation.

Effective loyalty programs also offer flexible reward structures, enabling you to implement various types of rewards like points, tiered discounts, and personalized promotions customized to customer preferences. Furthermore, the ability to create tiered programs encourages increased engagement, motivating customers to reach higher tiers for

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# Lazy Dynamic Programming

Tikhon Jelvis

Dynamic programming is a method for efficiently solving complex problems with overlapping subproblems, covered in any introductory algorithms course. It is usually presented in a staunchly imperative manner, explicitly reading from and modifying a mutable array—a method that doesn't neatly translate to a functional language like Haskell.

Happily, laziness provides a very natural way to express dynamic programming algorithms. The end result still relies on mutation, but purely by the runtime system—it is entirely below our level of abstraction. It's a great example of embracing and thinking with laziness.

So let's look at how to do dynamic programming in Haskell and implement string edit distance, which is one of the most commonly taught dynamic programming algorithms. In a future post, I will also extend this algorithm to trees.

The differences between two strings, as computed by the edit distance algorithm.

This post was largely spurred on by working with Joe Nelson as part of his “open source pilgrimage”. We worked on my semantic version control project which, as one of its passes, needs to compute a diff between parse trees with an algorithm deeply related to string edit distance as presented here. Pairing with Joe really helped me work out several of the key ideas in this post, which had me stuck a few years ago.

## Dynamic Programming and Memoization

Dynamic programming is one of the core techniques for writing efficient algorithms. The idea is to break a problem into smaller subproblems and then save the result of each subproblem so that it is only calculated once. Dynamic programming involves two parts: restating the problem in terms of overlapping subproblems and memoizing.

Overlapping subproblems are subproblems that depend on each other. This is where dynamic programming is needed: if we use the result of each subproblem many times, we can save time by caching each intermediate result, only calculating it once. Caching the result of a function like this is called memoization.

Memoization in general is a rich topic in Haskell. There are some very interesting approaches for memoizing functions over different sorts of inputs like Conal Elliott's elegant memoization or Luke Palmer's memo combinators.

The general idea is to take advantage of laziness and create a large data structure like a list or a tree that stores all of the function's results. This data structure is defined circularly: recursive calls are replaced with references to parts of the data structure. Thanks to laziness, pieces of the data structure only get evaluated as needed and at most once—memoization emerges naturally from the evaluation rules.

A very illustrative (but slightly cliché) example is the memoized version of the Fibonacci function:

The `fib` function indexes into `fib`s, an infinite list of Fibonacci numbers. `fib`s is defined in terms of itself: instead of recursively calling `fib`, we make later elements of `fib`s depend on earlier ones by passing `fib`s and (`drop 1 fib`s) into `zipWith (+)`. It helps to visualize this list as more and more elements get evaluated:

`zipWith f` applies `f` to the first elements of both lists then recurses on their tails. In this case, the two lists are actually just pointers into the same list!

Note how we only ever need the last two elements of the list. Since we don't have any other references to the `fib`s list, GHC's garbage collector can reclaim unused list elements as soon as we're done with them. So with GC, the actual execution looks more like this:

More memory efficient: we only ever store a constant number of past results.

`id="lazy-arrays">Lazy Arrays`

Dynamic programming algorithms tend to have a very specific memoization style—sub-problems are put into an array and the inputs to the algorithm are transformed into array indices. These algorithms are often presented in a distinctly imperative fashion: you initialize a large array with some empty value and then manually update it as you go along. You have to do some explicit bookkeeping at each step to save your result and there is nothing preventing you from accidentally reading in part of the array you haven't set yet.

This imperative-style updating is awkward to represent in Haskell. We could do it by either passing around an immutable array as an argument or using a mutable array internally, but both of these options are unpleasant to use and the former is not very efficient.

Instead of replicating the imperative approach directly, we're going to take advantage of Haskell's laziness to define an array that depends on itself. The trick is to have every recursive call in the function index into the array and each array cell call back into the function. This way, the logic of calculating each value once and then caching it is handled behind the scenes by Haskell's runtime system. We compute the subproblems at most once in the order that we need and the array is always used as if it was fully filled out: we can never accidentally forget to save a result or access the array before that result has been calculated.

At its heart, this is the same idea as having a `fib`s list that depends on itself, just with an array instead of a list. Arrays fit many dynamic programming problems better than lists or other data structures.

We can rewrite our `fib` function to use this style of memoization. Note that this approach is actually strictly worse for Fibonacci numbers; this is just an illustration of how it

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## “BTS: The Return” captures a poignant snapshot of a troubled comeback

Hanh Nguyen · Salon

BTS’ comeback could be likened to a classical Greek hero’s homecoming. After years at war – or performing military service as it were – they’re back to pick up where they left off with their lives, music and fans. But as with those ancient tales, such long-awaited returns aren’t without some conflict.

“There’s a long lineage of storytellers and filmmakers who have told part of BTS story, and for me, this moment was so pivotal and almost mythical,” director Bao Nguyen told members of the global press at a March 20 screening of his Netflix documentary, “BTS: The Return.”

“In a way for me, BTS is like Odysseus, and ARMY and the fans who are longing for BTS to return, are like Penelope. So I thought this moment was really special and unique.”

BTS – comprising members RM, Jin, Suga, J-Hope, Jimin, V and Jung Kook – took a collective hiatus in 2022 for each of them to participate in South Korean mandatory military service. Their staggered returns allowed for various solo releases and tours, and “The Return” catches up with the group as they hole up in Los Angeles for two months to write their fifth full studio album “Arirang,” which was released on March 20.

Nguyen, who’s garnered acclaim for his documentaries “The Greatest Night in Pop Music” and “The Stringer,” had the savvy to understand that the members themselves should be a part of telling their own story and put them to work.

“One of the things I knew going into the project is that we weren’t going to have free rein access to them at every minute, every second of their time in Los Angeles,” he said. “What was important to me was to view their story through their own perspective. So I had this idea of giving them each these mini DV camcorders, which you see in the film, and I wanted them to document when our crew wasn’t around, because for me, that type of archival and home video footage, it feels like your dad or your uncle going around and shooting you, right? There’s something so intimate about that type of footage.”

Nguyen deftly crafts a poignant and contemplative snapshot of these seven bonded men who are caught between several masters in the creation of “Arirang.” At times their own desires and tastes take a backseat to the demands of others, and Nguyen also captures moments when candid feelings of frustration and ambivalence slip through. Expect ARMY to dissect the film forensically as their protective instincts are activated.

A matter of timing vs. the ticking clock

In the film, group leader RM (real name Kim Namjoon) mulls over two Greek concepts of time, one of which is the qualitative *kairos*, in which acting a certain way in the

perfect moment has a lasting impact. This requires understanding context, the desired intent and having the ability to act in that moment.

The concept appears to drive RM and the other BTS members during their Los Angeles retreat as they probe their own identity post-military and whether what they have to say is worthwhile and proper for the album. They have an ongoing conversation about which song deserves to be the lead single to be released first. While some members gravitate toward the album’s first track, “Body to Body,” which includes snippets of the traditional Korean folk song “Ari-rang” in it, the more romantic “Swim” is pushed forward. Was this the right song for this moment? Nguyen captures the ambivalence and anxiety surrounding these decisions.

“To be honest, the group was so vulnerable with what they said. They were actually giving us and the camera more than I expected,” said Nguyen. “Like I mentioned ‘The Odyssey’ was a frame of reference for me in entering the story, and then we were sitting in the car with RM, and then he starts talking about *kairos* and *chronos* out of nowhere . . . and in my mind. I was like, ‘Oh, my God, the synergy of this is something that you can’t direct.’

“It’s interesting what they think about when they’re alone. We didn’t have the intention to do traditional sit-down interviews, and so for me, I wanted to get in the interiority of each of the members somehow. And if you’ve ever been to LA, there’s a lot of driving, and when you’re sitting in a car, you do a lot of thinking. And naturally they would just talk to us when they were sitting there, kind of watching the palm trees go by. Those moments of vulnerability and intimacy were given to us by the members.”

In a sense, Bao Nguyen also must weigh *kairos* in the making of “The Return” such as when the seven BTS members go to a beach and are able to maintain enough anonymity that they’re not mobbed.

“One moment of gatekeeping, though, was the public beach scene that we shot in Santa Monica,” said producer Jane Cha Cutler. “I mean, we were scared that it was going to turn into a like a Beatles moment. But we all played it cool, and somehow they were able to have a fun private day that turns out to be a beautiful moment in the film.”

Producer Namjo Kim added, “When it comes to shooting a documentary, I feel like what’s really important is the ‘wait’ part of it more so than the actual filming part of it. And I think Director Bao did an amazing job in sort of waiting it out to make sure that he captured the very genuine, authentic moments of creativity, of inner struggles and of the weight of the responsibility that each of the members felt in this process. That was a very critical element to all of this.”

Waiting, however, is not a luxury that BTS has. That other Greek concept is *chronos*, which refers to chronological or sequential time and is quantitative. It relentlessly moves forward independent of a person’s actions or desires.

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## BRIEFS

**The Hacker News, The Hacker News (cybersecurity):** The North Korean threat actors behind the Contagious Interview campaign, also tracked as WaterPlum, have been attributed to a malware family tracked as StoaWaffle that's distributed via malicious Microsoft Visual Studio Code (VS Code) projects. The use of VS Code "tasks.json" to distribute malware is a relatively new tactic adopted by the threat actor since December 2025, with the attacks

**Juliana Kim, NPR News:** Advocates for ending birthright citizenship point to "birth tourism" schemes to argue that the legal principle is ripe for exploitation and threatens national security. Experts say it's not so simple.

(Image credit: Mark Schiefelbein)

**Makena Finger Zannini, Entrepreneur:** Most small businesses don't actually need a new CRM or a salesperson when revenue feels shaky — they need to tighten their fundamentals.

**The Hacker News, The Hacker News (cybersecurity):** On February 25, 2026, Gartner published its inaugural Market Guide for Guardian Agents, marking an important milestone for this emerging category. For those unfamiliar with the various Gartner report types, "a Market Guide defines a market and explains what clients can expect it to do in the short term. With the focus on early, more chaotic markets, a Market Guide does not rate or position

**Wendy Benjaminson, Bloomberg:** US President Donald Trump speaks during a swearing-in ceremony in the Oval Office of the White House in Washington, DC, US, on Tuesday, March 24, 2026. Markwayne Mullin was confirmed Department of Homeland Security secretary, placing the Oklahoma senator in charge of a Trump administration immigration crackdown that has triggered a 37-day funding shutdown of the cabinet agency.

**Michael Levitt, NPR News:** Finding a job is hard right now, especially for young people starting their careers. NPR's Adrian Ma spoke with college students and an economist about navigating today's tough job market.

**Ben Westcott, Bloomberg:** A 'Sorry This Hose Not In Use' sign covers a pump at a Shell petrol station in Sydney, Australia, on Wednesday, March 25, 2026.

**The Hacker News, The Hacker News (cybersecurity):** Another week, another reminder that the internet is still a mess. Systems people thought were secure are being broken in simple ways, showing many still ignore basic advisories. This edition covers a mix of issues: supply chain attacks hitting CI/CD setups, long-abused IoT devices being shut down, and exploits moving quickly from disclosure to real attacks. There are also new malware tricks

**The Hacker News, The Hacker News (cybersecurity):** A 26-year-old Russian citizen has been sentenced in the U. S. to 6.75 years (81 months) in prison for his role in assisting major cybercrime groups, including the Yanluowang ransomware crew, in conducting numerous attacks against U. S. companies and other organizations. According to the U. S. Department of Justice (DoJ), Aleksei Olegovich Volkov facilitated dozens of ransomware attacks across the

**The Hacker News, The Hacker News (cybersecurity):** An ongoing phishing campaign is targeting French-speaking corporate environments with fake resumes that lead to the deployment of cryptocurrency miners and information stealers. "The campaign uses highly obfuscated VBScript files disguised as resume/CV documents, delivered through phishing emails," Securonix researchers Shikha Sangwan, Akshay Gaikwad, and Aaron Beardslee said in a report shared

**The Hacker News, The Hacker News (cybersecurity):** Cybersecurity researchers are calling attention to an active device code phishing campaign that's targeting Microsoft 365 identities across more than 340 organizations in the U. S., Canada, Australia, New Zealand, and Germany. The activity, per Huntress, was first spotted on February 19, 2026, with subsequent cases appearing at an accelerated pace since then. Notably, the campaign leverages

**Jeff Brady, NPR News:** Even when Transportation Security Administration workers get paid, Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents could still be present at U. S. airports.

(Image credit: David J. Phillip)

**Tikhon Jelvis, Tikhon Jelvis:** Experts aren't just beginners with more knowledge, they operate in a fundamentally different way. How can we empower rather than hinder them?

**The Hacker News, The Hacker News (cybersecurity):** Two more GitHub Actions workflows have become the latest to be compromised by credential-stealing malware by a threat actor known as TeamPCP, the cloud-native cybercriminal operation also behind the Trivy supply chain attack. The workflows, both maintained by the supply chain security company Checkmarx, are listed below -

checkmarx/ast-github-action checkmarx/kics-github-action

Cloud security

**Scott Horsley, NPR News:** Nearly all the bicycles sold in the United States are made overseas. An Indiana company set out to change that — and it's seeking a push from the Trump administration's tariffs.

(Image credit: Scott Horsley)

**Aleksandra Wrona, Snopes:** Schumer's wife, Iris Weinshall, is the New York Public Library's chief operating officer. There's no evidence she ever owned a cleaning company.

**Carrie Johnson, NPR News:** Pauline Newman's story shines a light on the aging judiciary, where judges are getting older and lifetime tenure is raising thorny questions about retirement.

(Image credit: Paul J. Richards)

**The Hacker News, The Hacker News (cybersecurity):** The U.S. Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency (CISA) and Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) have announced a joint operation to disrupt a threat actor known as TeamPCP, the cloud-native cybercriminal operation also behind the Trivy supply chain attack. The operation, which is part of a larger effort to disrupt the threat actor's infrastructure, involves the seizure of accounts belonging to individuals with high intelligence value, the U. S. Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency (CISA) and Federal Bureau of

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